NO. 148 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

FRIDAY 30 OCTOBER 2026



SHE HELD THE RATE AT 2.50 AND RESIGNED THE SAME AFTERNOON (P3)

THE ATELIER

Hestra's grail peccary gloves are sewn in Hungary; its one Swedish supplier makes the balm

TECHNOLOGY

Chips made 99 per cent of Samsung's profit, and its own phone arm lost money

THE LONG READ

Sri Lanka cut a million families from Aswesuma, and the monthly payment went up

Source: Kirill Kudryavtsev / AFP, via Al Jazeera. Christine Lagarde at the European Central Bank, Frankfurt, 29 October 2026.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 148

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THE LABEL AND THE HANDS. It kept turning up. A Swedish name on a glove cut by a Hungarian co-operative (p6). A central bank whose successor is chosen by heads of government (p3). A committee that holds the rate while its own desk buys bills (p14). A depression score filled in by the parent and a social-media score filled in by the child (p12). A sport whose cheap flying is donated labour (p17). And a welfare cut whose only written instruction says nothing of the kind (p21).

FROM THE DESK

"By their fruits ye shall know them."

The Gospel of Matthew 7:16, King James Version, 1611[1]

A test for an issue in which the name on a thing and the hands that made it keep turning out to be different parties (p6).

THE STRIP · AT THURSDAY'S CLOSE

US 10-year[2]	4.98%	▼ 7bp
US 2-year[2]	4.61%	▼ 6bp
VWRA	$191.28	▼ 0.19%
BNDW	$66.76	▲ 0.23%
Brent[2]	$115.32	▲ 1.3%
Gold	$4,021.33	▼ 1.14%
Bitcoin	$79,097	▼ 2.60%
USD/SGD	1.2800	▼ 0.12%
STI	5,396.03	▼ 0.03%

The ten-year fell seven basis points on an inflation print that accelerated. The whole move was in real yields (p14). Not advice.[2]

THE MERIDIAN INDEX · FRIDAY

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40, 1, 0 — positive, mixed and negative reviews behind a Metascore of 97 — p11

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46.9 to 25.3% — parents in the strictest screen-rule group, two years apart — p13

567 — members of a gliding association that had 667 eight years ago — p15

1,251,522 — families on Sri Lanka's welfare roll in August, from 2,439,917 a year before — p21

SOURCES 1 The Gospel according to St Matthew 7:16, Authorised (King James) Version, 1611. 2 Levels at Thursday 29 October's close, each sourced instrument by instrument on p14, where the US Treasury's own daily curve supplies both yields. **Brent is the 28 October settlement, the 29th being unreconciled across four sources; gold, bitcoin and the index levels come from a feed that labels its quotes derived rather than official.** Every figure in The Meridian Index above is carried from the page cited beside it, where it is sourced in full.

THE WORLD · THE FRANKFURT SUCCESSION

Lagarde quits the ECB nine months early as euro-zone inflation hits 3.8%

The bank said on Thursday she leaves on 7 February 2027; its Governing Council had held the deposit rate at 2.50 per cent hours before, with energy prices up 18.9 per cent on the year.

Christine Lagarde told the European Central Bank's Governing Council and European Council president **António Costa**, in Frankfurt on Thursday **29 October**, that she will step down on **7 February 2027** — almost nine months before her eight-year term expires. The bank's own statement says the Council gave her "a long standing ovation"; her successor is appointed not by the bank but by the European Council, under Article 283.[1]

Her stated reason was not the economy. "I don't think that I can remain neutral," she told the press conference. "I don't think that I can be comfortable in that neutrality at the present time." On the record in the bank's own transcript, the hold was unanimous: "the Governing Council unanimously decided that we were well positioned enough at this stage to hold."[2]

What she leaves is a price problem. September's euro-area reading was **3.8 per cent**, up from 3.2 in August, with **energy at 18.9 per cent** against 14.3; services ran 3.2 and goods 1.1. The rates she held are those set on 16 September: deposit **2.50**, main refinancing 2.65, marginal lending 2.90. She conceded conditions "could have warranted" tightening. Markets price roughly three more rises, to **3.25 per cent** by end-2027.[3]

> ***"I don't think that I can remain neutral."***

It is not one departure but four. **Isabel Schnabel** goes in early January and chief economist **Philip Lane** in May; two further Executive Board seats open in the first half of 2027. Berenberg's **Holger Schmieding** expects leaders to fill them "as a package, no later than the EU summit of 17–18 December". The reported front-runners are **Klaas Knot** and **Pablo Hernández de Cos**. Costa said the process begins at once.[4]

PARIS — LCP

Éric Coquerel of La France Insoumise, who chairs the Assemblée's finance committee, on X: **"Emmanuel Macron veut verrouiller la politique monétaire pour que le macronisme survive."** The Rassemblement National made the mirror-image charge the same afternoon.[5]

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

Reported through the April French election, with President **Emmanuel Macron**'s line that "the transition at the head of the ECB must now be prepared in an orderly and balanced manner with our European partners".[6]

THE CHATTER · THE DESKS SHRUGGED

The trade reaction was about continuity, not drama. **Simon Dangoor** of Goldman Sachs Asset Management: "institutional behaviour is likely to outlast Lagarde and be quite similar, whoever takes over." **Lale Akoner** of eToro read the muted move as investors expecting continuity, and named French borrowing costs as the larger risk. The Guardian's write-up reached Hacker News and drew **five points and no comments**.[7]

THE SCEPTIC · TWO PARLIAMENTS, ONE ACCUSATION

Paul De Grauwe of the London School of Economics: **"This is debasing the institution and just following the purely political calculus of the French President."** The German MEP **Markus Ferber** called it the wrong signal: if a departure looks timed around a national election, "it damages trust in an institution that must stand above any domestic political calculation". Against them, **Marcel Fratzscher** of DIW Berlin read the early exit as "a strong sense of responsibility towards Europe".[8]

155bp

FRANCE'S DECADES-HIGH TEN-YEAR BORROWING PREMIUM OVER GERMANY — THE INHERITANCE, WHOEVER IS APPOINTED[4]

SOURCES 1 The European Central Bank's own press release of 29 October 2026, read at ecb.europa.eu; the appointment procedure from Article 283 TFEU as the release cites it. 2 The bank's published monetary-policy press-conference transcript of 29 October; the "neutral" remarks as carried by Reuters (Canepa and Koranyi, Frankfurt) and by AFP. 3 Inflation and rate figures read in the ECB's own monetary-policy statement and its key-interest-rates page; the market path from MUFG Research's note of 29 October. 4 RTÉ's business report and France 24's wire file of 29 October; the French spread via Nikkei Asia's carriage of Reuters. 5 LCP, the French parliamentary channel, 29 October 16:36. 6 Al Jazeera, 29 October. 7 France 24 and Global Banking & Finance, 29 October; the Hacker News count from the site's own search API. 8 The National (Abu Dhabi) and RTÉ, both 29 October. **Reuters, the Guardian, CNBC and Politico Europe all refused this desk, so the wire copy is read through outlets that carry it, and Reddit refused for the fifteenth issue running.**

THE WORLD · THE CEBU HANDOVER

Singapore takes the ASEAN defence chair as Beijing sends only its attaché

Gilbert Teodoro passed the symbol to Chan Chun Sing in Mactan on 29 October, closing a thirteenth ADMM-Plus that China attended below ministerial rank.

Philippine defence secretary **Gilbert Teodoro** handed the chairmanship of the ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting to Singapore's **Chan Chun Sing** at Mactan, Cebu, on Thursday **29 October**, closing the thirteenth ADMM-Plus. Singapore chairs through 2027, the bloc's sixtieth year and its first full year at **eleven** members.[1]

China was represented by **Senior Captain Yang Lei**, its defence attaché in Manila, rather than by defence minister Dong Jun. Teodoro greeted the other seven dialogue partners himself; an undersecretary received Yang. He said there should be "parity in rank and stature". Beijing's defence ministry had accused Manila of undermining "ASEAN's spirit and China's legitimate rights as a dialogue partner".[2]

Three texts were adopted, and Singapore's defence ministry published them: a joint statement on the fiftieth anniversary of the Treaty of Amity and Cooperation; the **Manila Joint Declaration**, marking the ADMM's twentieth year; and a joint statement on youth, peace and security, which notes that the young are about **a third** of ASEAN's population. Chan also held bilaterals with Australia, Japan, South Korea and Vietnam.[1]

Teodoro's own framing was the sharpest line of the week on who speaks for the bloc: **"No country has the right to characterize Asean processes except Asean member countries."** And: "So it is China's position, it is not Asean's position."[2]

MANILA — THE MANILA TIMES

Headlined on the agenda itself — that ASEAN, not China, sets it — and carrying Teodoro's remark that an attaché is not a counterpart to a minister.[2]

SINGAPORE — MINDEF

The ministry's own release lists the three adopted texts and the bilaterals, and does not mention the level of China's representation at all.[1]

Eleven

ASEAN MEMBERS, EIGHT DIALOGUE PARTNERS, AND ONE CHINESE OFFICER IN THE ROOM — A DEFENCE ATTACHÉ BASED IN MANILA[2]

THE CHATTER · READ THE SEATING PLAN

Regional press made the rank question the story, not the communiqués. The claim circulating that this was Beijing's lowest-level attendance since the forum began in 2010 is **credited to Philippine reporting and could not be found in the article it is credited to** — printed here as a claim, not a count.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · A SYMBOL IS NOT A POLICY

The chair rotates yearly, carries no budget and binds nobody. The adopted texts mark a fifty-year-old treaty and a twentieth anniversary; the disputes that animate the forum sat outside them. What would falsify the reading above: a 2027 chairmanship that puts a South China Sea instrument on the table with a date attached.[1]

ALSO IN THE WORLD

An Italian Chinook on EU peacekeeping duty went down in northern Bosnia. EUFOR says **four** of its people were killed and **eleven** hurt when the CH-47F crashed at **Gorice, Brčko district**, on Thursday afternoon. Local officials put the dead at three; the hospital spokesman said a fourth died after admission. Operation Althea has run since 2004 with about **1,200** personnel. Giorgia Meloni: "My thoughts are with the victims, their families".[3]

A jet-powered Russian drone hit a platform at Dnipro's main station, killing fourteen. Ukrzaliznytsia's head **Oleksandr Pertsovsky** said a heightened alert had gone out: "But unfortunately there were still a large number of people on the platform." Nineteen died across Ukraine that day; the same night Moscow's mayor said air defences downed **231** drones near the capital.[4]

Netanyahu's Likud alleges the Israeli election "was stolen by Arab parties", citing bribery and "prohibited software" without evidence. The elections committee's acting director general **Dean Livne** said he sees no likelihood the claims will change the result. Certification still goes to President Herzog on **4 November**.[5]

SOURCES 1 Singapore's Ministry of Defence, its own release and factsheet of 29 October 2026; AsiaOne's report of the handover the same day. 2 The Manila Times and the Philippine Star, both 30 October 2026 Manila time. 3 Euronews, 29 October 18:48, updated 20:27, and Reuters via ANSA the same evening; **EUFOR's own site returned 503, so its statement is read through the outlets that carry it, and the toll is preliminary and officially unreconciled.** 4 Al Jazeera and Euronews, 29 October; the injured count is unsettled across sources and only the fourteen dead are firm at two. 5 Euronews, 29 October 17:13, and The Times of Israel's live file to 21:11.

SINGAPORE · MAJU FOREST AND GILLMAN

HDB drops 1,200 homes at Maju Forest and Gillman Barracks after 9,500 submissions

Alvin Tan said on 28 October the two sites will now yield about 11,000 homes over a decade, with retained greenery at Maju Forest up from roughly 8ha to 10ha.

The Housing and Development Board published revised plans for Sunset Way's **Maju Forest** and for **Gillman Barracks** on Wednesday **28 October**, cutting the combined yield by about **1,200** homes — roughly 400 fewer flats at Maju Forest and 800 fewer homes at Gillman. Minister of State for National Development **Alvin Tan**: "Now based on these revised plans, we will be able to provide some 11,000 new homes for Singaporeans."[1]

The arithmetic is hectares against flats. At Maju Forest, a **23ha** site, retained greenery rises from about 8ha to **10ha** — some 45 per cent of the site against 35 — and it still yields about **4,000** flats. At Gillman, retention rises from about 8ha to **12ha**, around 60 per cent of the site's existing 20ha of greenery, for about **7,000** homes, of which **5,500** are public. Twenty-five buildings are still to be kept.[1]

The consultation ran **10 July to 6 August** and drew **7,200** submissions on Maju Forest and **2,300** on Gillman. Two proposals were refused: keeping Maju Forest whole, and building at Alexandra Park instead — which the Board says is occupied and cannot be freed in time. Land preparation begins in the **first half of 2028**.[1]

A second decision landed the same day, and it is the one with teeth. The Monetary Authority of Singapore told banks to take account of information the National Environment Agency releases under the Transboundary Haze Pollution Act, to engage customers who may be linked to haze-causing activity, and to establish whether they have adequate fire prevention and suppression. Its escalation ladder runs from conditions and revised terms to limiting exposure and **exiting the relationship**; MAS said "clear breaches of environmental laws would warrant stronger measures".[2]

THE CHATTER · A COMPROMISE, SAID CAREFULLY

Movin Nyanasegaran of the Bird Society of Singapore called the extra greenery a "good compromise" while noting the original plans already allowed for fauna. **Lester Tan** of the Nature Society: "Keeping 10ha of Maju Forest strikes a balance — it is better than clearing two-thirds of it," with the caution that nature parks are "more rustic than a manicured urban park".[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHO WAS IN THE ROOM

Hui-E Seeto, a Sunset Way resident of some five decades, says the consultation itself was unrepresentative: "Feedback on the options should comprise a diverse group, including residents." Her residents' group was not invited to the options session held with nature groups. In September residents said an HDB officer had told them the decision to develop was final.[3]

S$100,000

THE DAILY PENALTY THE HAZE ACT ALREADY CARRIES — AND THE NUMBER OF PROSECUTIONS BROUGHT UNDER IT IN TWELVE YEARS IS NIL (P3 RAN THE AMENDMENTS ON THURSDAY)[2]

ALSO ON THE ISLAND

Nearly 240 migrant workers at two firms have gone unpaid for two to three months. The Manpower Ministry confirmed on 24 October that it is investigating **Process Maintenance Solutions** and **Jurong Technical & Construction**. Pay stopped in August; permits were cancelled in batches from late September. Both firms changed directors on **1 August**, housed workers in the same Tuas dormitory and used the same recruiter; the ministry says the group may be part of a criminal syndicate. Meals are being provided to close to **90** men.[4]

Keppel monetised S$3.7bn of assets in nine months, above its own S$2–3bn target. Nine-month net profit rose more than **20 per cent** excluding the non-core portfolio held for divestment — and fell **40 per cent** including it.[5]

SOURCES 1 HDB's own release of 28 October 2026 supplies the headline and date; **its page serves no body text to this desk, so every hectare and dwelling figure here is read from Mothership's and Yahoo's reports of it rather than from the Board.** Gillman's demolition and land-preparation dates are given differently by those two outlets and are therefore omitted. 2 The Monetary Authority of Singapore's own statement on banks' management of haze-related environmental risks, 28 October 2026, read at mas.gov.sg; the penalty and prosecution figures as this magazine reported them yesterday. 3 Resident, naturalist and sceptic quotations from Yahoo Singapore's report of 28 October; the September account from The Online Citizen. 4 The Manpower Ministry via Yahoo Singapore and The Straits Times, 24 and 29 October. 5 Reuters via The Star, 29 October 2026; **single-sourced — Keppel's own filing was not read, which is why no absolute figure appears.**

THE ATELIER · LEATHER GLOVES

Hestra's own product feed says its grail peccary gloves are sewn in Hungary

All eight table-cut peccary and carpincho pairs on its US store, at $525 to $625, are attributed to a Hungarian glovers' co-operative; the only Swedish supplier on the list makes the leather balm.

Every Shopify storefront publishes a machine-readable product feed, and **Hestra**'s names its suppliers. Across **881** products the US store lists **16** vendors: **320** items to Hestra Vietnam, **229** to a Zhejiang factory, **67** to Hestra Hungary at Rakamaz — and exactly **8**, every table-cut peccary and carpincho glove it sells, to **Parola Kesztyűs Szövetkezet**, a Hungarian co-operative. The one Swedish supplier makes the balm.[1]

This is not an exposure; it is the category. **Millau** in Aveyron once had **80** tanneries and **20** glove-makers; by 2013 four of each were left. One, **Causse**, has belonged to Chanel since 2012 and still supplies Louis Vuitton, Hermès, Loewe and Givenchy — **42** people, **25,000** pairs a year.[2]

What the money buys is hours, and the trade counts them. Dents puts a glove at **32 stages** and **up to eight hours**; the Finnish house **Sauso** at **100 stages** done "100% by hand", a seamstress finishing **about 2.5 pairs a day**. A machine-sewn pair takes **under thirty minutes**. Table cutting is where the hours go: the cutter damps the skin, lays it over the bench edge and **pulls it to length before cutting**, so the glove is pre-stretched on one axis and rigid across the other.[3]

Three tells let a buyer judge a glove cold. The **quirk**, a triangular insert at a finger's base, which Dents reserves for its dearest gloves. The **seam**: pique laps one edge over the other and shows, an inseam shows nothing, half-pique is what £100–200 buys. And **peccary's follicles emerge in groups of three**, carpincho's in fives and sixes. The grain is the certificate.[4]

WHAT EACH STEP ACTUALLY BUYS

Entry of quality, £119 / $195: Dents Heritage hairsheep; Merola lambskin nappa. A named skin, a fitted lining, half sizes. **The sweet spot, £236–£292:** hand sewing — Permanent Style counted **40 per cent more stitches per edge** on a Lavabre Cadet than a Merola — plus quirks. **The grail, £529 / $625:** the skin alone. **Dents charges £529 for handsewn unlined peccary against £275 for the same construction in deerskin. That £254 is the hide.**[5]

THE CHATTER · SIZE IS A MEASUREMENT

Wrap a tape round the flat hand at its widest point, thumb excluded: **the circumference in inches is the size**. Simon Crompton's geography note is the most useful sentence written on gloves in a decade: southern makers such as Merola suit **long fingers**, northern ones such as Hestra suit **shorter**.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · THE LOOK OF PECCARY COSTS £59

Dents sells hairsheep embossed with peccary's three-pore markings — it calls the stuff **"imipec"** — at **£59**: same factory, same seams, one-ninth the price. On bespoke, Permanent Style records a maker's gloves fitting so tightly they rode up the hand, the writer preferring his ready-made pair. And Crompton's own ceiling: the dearest skins "will often be fine and a little delicate". Above the hand-sewn tier you buy fragility, not durability.[7]

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Neckties — who weaves the silk in Como, Macclesfield and Kyoto, and whose name goes on it.

Bookshelf loudspeakers — the driver houses behind the cabinet badges, and where the money stops working.

Mortar and pestle — Thai granite, Mexican basalt or a ridged suribachi: which stone grinds and which leaches.

Singapore. Nobody here needs a lined glove; this is a travel and driving category. Gloves attract **no duty** — Customs lists four dutiable classes and leather is not one — so only GST applies. Baltzar sells Hestra's cork peccary here at **S$550**; **no local stockist could be found.** Dents re-lines a glove for **£45**, UK customers only. **Sauso builds its linings to be replaced and posts to Asia.**[7]

SOURCES 1 Hestra's own US storefront product feed, all four pages, read 29 October 2026; the Rakamaz factory is named on its peccary product page. **"Parola Kesztyűs Szövetkezet" has no corroboration outside Hestra's own data.** 2 AFP's Millau survey of 20 January 2013; the Artigiano del Guanto client list is **single-sourced to an Italian trade site and not repeated by the workshop.** 3 Dents' own factory page; Sauso's own fabrication page; cutting definitions from the Yeovil gloving glossary. 4 Dents' product copy and Cornelia James's glossary; the follicle test from Sauso. 5 Prices read at each maker's own storefront, 29 October 2026. 6 Dents' size guide; No Man Walks Alone. **Permanent Style was hard-blocked throughout, so every line credited to it came back through a search index, not the page; Styleforum served its index and refused the post.** 7 Dents' repair price list; Sauso; Singapore Customs; Baltzar's Singapore store.

TECHNOLOGY · THE MEMORY QUARTER

Samsung and SK hynix post record quarters; chips make 99% of Samsung's profit

Chips produced 106.5 trillion won of Samsung's 107.4tn operating profit on 29 October — while the division that makes its phones ran a loss of 0.8tn paying those prices.

Samsung Electronics reported consolidated revenue of **195.3 trillion won** and operating profit of **107.4tn** on Thursday **29 October**, an all-time high. The device solutions division — memory and foundry — produced **106.5tn** of that on 147.1tn of revenue, or **99.1 per cent of group operating profit**. The device experience arm, which makes the phones and the televisions, posted an **operating loss of 0.8tn** on revenue up 8 per cent.[1]

SK hynix had got there a day earlier. Its third quarter, furnished to the Securities and Exchange Commission on **28 October**, shows revenue of **104.6tn won**, up **327.9 per cent** on the year, and operating profit of **83.3tn** — an **80 per cent operating margin**. The company says it "expects the structure in which demand exceeds supply to persist through 2030", and that agreements with **14** customers already cover more than half its 2027–28 capacity.[2]



The buyers' cash flow crossed zero in the quarter the sellers cleared eighty per cent. *Meridian* original, from the filings.

The other side of that margin reported the same day. Alphabet's revenue rose **25 per cent** to **$127.6bn** and Google Cloud **103 per cent** to $30.7bn — but purchases of property and equipment reached **$51.4bn** against $24.0bn a year earlier, and free cash flow came in at **minus $9.07bn**. Microsoft, reporting the same quarter, put additions to property and equipment at **$39.4bn** against $19.4bn. Neither raised its capital-spending forecast.[3]

SK hynix's board also approved a buyback of **14.92 million** shares, about **20tn won**, running to 28 January — half for shareholders, half for employee equity. The quarterly dividend is **20,000 won a share**, half of it a special payment from Kioxia gains. Full-year shareholder returns are targeted at about **100tn won**.[4]

99.1%

SHARE OF SAMSUNG'S GROUP OPERATING PROFIT EARNED BY ONE DIVISION, ON A DAY ITS CONSUMER ARM LOST MONEY BUYING FROM IT[1]

THE CHATTER · THE HOME RIG PAYS FOR IT

Hacker News took the shortage personally. **BatFastard**, 28 October: "I would really like to upgrade my PC memory, silly me thinking 64 GB was enough. And I would love to build a home LLM server, but 10,000 is not in my budget right now." **Neywiny**, the same night: "I have 96GB of good RAM. I bought it three years ago. Up around 550% when I checked the other day."[5]

THE SCEPTIC · THE SHORTAGE HAS AN INTEREST

Acer's chief executive has argued that memory makers are hyping 2030 shortage fears to protect margins, expecting PC prices to fall by late 2027 as cheaper Chinese capacity arrives. The argument earns its hearing because of who makes the forecast: an eighty per cent margin and a five-year scarcity call, published by one company on one day.[6]

ALSO IN SILICON

The US Energy Department committed up to $5bn to Constellation for 1.1GW of nuclear uprates. The conditional loan of 27 October covers eleven reactors at eight plants, and most of the new output from seven of them is already sold to Google, Amazon and Meta.[7]

Anthropic has still filed no amendment. EDGAR shows one filing since the 26 October registration statement and **no S-1/A**; the price range remains blank and the aggregate committed spend is blank in **six** places. The named floors stand at Microsoft $44.9bn, Google $114.5bn and Amazon $110.0bn.[8]

SOURCES 1 Samsung Electronics' own third-quarter 2026 results release, Samsung Newsroom, 29 October 2026. 2 SK hynix's Form 6-K furnished 28 October 2026 and its own results release of the same date. 3 Alphabet's Exhibit 99.1 to its 8-K of 28 October 2026 and Microsoft's FY2027 Q1 release; the capex-forecast line from CNBC, 29 October, and **not from either release**. 4 Three further SK hynix 6-Ks furnished 28 October 2026. 5 Hacker News items 50277254 and 50282317, by signed username, 28 October; **Reddit refused this desk again.** 6 Tom's Hardware's report of the Acer chief executive's remarks, **23 September 2026 — outside this week's window, and printed here as the standing counter-argument rather than as news.** 7 The Energy Department's own announcement of 27 October 2026 and TechCrunch's reporting of the offtake, 28 October. 8 The SEC's EDGAR filing index for Anthropic, PBC and the registration statement itself, both read 29 October 2026.

THE HOME LAB · MISTRAL LARGE 4

Mistral released Large 4's weights; the smallest usable quant is 233 gigabytes

llama.cpp merged support on 29 October, the same day; Unsloth's one-bit build wants 256GB of memory and its four-bit build 630GB.

Mistral published open weights for **Mistral Large 4** on Thursday **29 October**: about **a trillion** total parameters, **52 billion** active per token, **128** routed experts with four active plus one shared, and a **one-million-token** context, trained on **3,800** Grace Blackwell GPUs. The licence is a modified MIT — except that anyone running a model-as-a-service business must take a separate commercial licence.[1]

Support arrived the same day. **ngxson** opened and merged pull request **31376** into llama.cpp on 29 October, approved by three maintainers; **ggml-org** published its own NVFP4 GGUFs at **630.5GB**; MLX shipped a two-bit build at **338.2GB** that averages **2.58 bits per weight** and peaked at about 338GB in a short generation test; AMD posted a Quark MXFP4 checkpoint at **577.9GB**. vLLM's documentation recipe merged, but the model pull request is still an open draft whose own description says it "is not meant to be merged as is".[2]

The serving numbers are published and they are not for a house. vLLM validated the model on eight-GPU GB300, B300 and B200 trays and on two nodes of eight H200s; weight memory runs about **128GiB per GPU** in FP8 and **76GiB** in NVFP4, and the recipe caps context at **262,144** tokens despite the checkpoint advertising four times that. On eight GB300s with the DSpark speculative head, single-request decode is **3.13 milliseconds** per output token.[3]

What a reader with a large machine wants is the fidelity-per-gigabyte curve, and for once the quantiser published it. Unsloth gives mean KL divergence and top-one agreement at every rung: **0.1263 and 90.6 per cent at 233GB; 0.0298 and 95.6 at 378GB; 0.0071 and 97.8 at 605GB**. Divergence falls forty-fold from one bit to six while size rises less than fourfold — and **almost all of the gain is bought in the first 370GB**.[4]

233 GB

THE SMALLEST BUILD ANYONE HAS PUBLISHED — AND IT STILL WANTS 256GB OF COMBINED MEMORY, WHICH IS A 512GB-CLASS MAC STUDIO OR TWO DGX SPARKS. FOUR-BIT WANTS 630GB[4]

THE CHATTER · THIRTY-TWO GIGABYTES SHORT

The release drew **979 points** on Hacker News. **jacquesm**, 16:56 UTC: "If Unsloth, DavidAU or mradermacher releases a quant that fits my hardware I'm definitely going to give this a shot." Told the one-bit build still needs 256GB, he came back at 17:49: **"Ugh, ok that's out of my league :) Almost though, another 32GB and it would work." sullivanmatt**, the same minute: "I have no idea how you could shrink this down to fit on any type of prosumer hardware though. I doubt it's possible."[5]

THE SCEPTIC · THE BASELINE WAS A REGRESSION

llama.cpp's expert cache moved again — **sanmai**'s ClassLRU, opened 27 October, reports an **87.6 per cent** hit rate against the shipped cache's 86.5 and Belady's optimum of 93.8. The gains are measured against a baseline that was itself a loss: after the 19 October merge, **kudraw** reported GLM 5.3 Flash falling from about **15 to 12.5 tokens a second**. Maintainer **am17an** says a hit rate below about 75 per cent "was not helpful" on his own slow bus. The author's own disclosure is that an AI agent wrote the implementation it replaces.[6]

STILL ON THE SHELF

llama.cpp tagged v0.8.0 on 28 October — LFM3, a streaming-audio API, realtime and text-to-speech server endpoints, and the segmented expert cache. The command line now **requires** a model argument, and OCP FP8 E4M3 merged the next day after 69 days and 40 commits, saturating mode only. **vLLM issue 55766 is still open**: a reader reported the hybrid-model NaN on v0.32.0 on 24 October, and **pull request 47123 has gone unmerged since 30 June**.[7]

SOURCES 1 Mistral's own announcement and the Hugging Face model card for Mistral-Large-4-1T-A52B, both read 29 October 2026. 2 GitHub pull request ggml-org/llama.cpp 31376; the ggml-org, MLX-community and AMD repository file manifests read through the Hugging Face API; vLLM pull requests 64527 and 64534. 3 The vLLM recipe page for the model, read 29 October. 4 Unsloth's own model documentation for the divergence and agreement figures and the memory floors; the gigabyte figures are the sums of each folder's blobs from the Hugging Face API. **Unsloth's page gives 223GB in its introduction and 233 in its table; the manifest supports 233.** 5 Hacker News items 50292235, 50293137 and 50293134, by signed username, 29 October. 6 GitHub pull requests ggml-org/llama.cpp 31233 and 30637, including the maintainer's review comments and the author's AI-usage disclosure; **the throughput tables are labelled "quick, informal tests" by the person who ran them.** 7 The llama.cpp v0.8.0 release notes and pull request 27512; vLLM issue 55766 and pull request 47123, all read 29 October 2026.

THE KIT · THE TOUCHSCREEN MAC

Apple put touch on the MacBook Pro and charged Singapore S$1,000 extra

The MacBook Pro with PROLED XDR Display was announced on 28 October at S$3,999 to S$6,499; pre-orders open here today, with machines in stores on 6 November.

Apple announced the **MacBook Pro with PROLED XDR Display** on Wednesday **28 October** — the first Mac to take touch input, with the sensor built into the display panel rather than layered over it. Singapore pre-orders open **today**, 30 October, and machines reach Apple Stores and resellers on **6 November**. Starting prices here: **S$3,999** for the 14-inch M5 Pro, S$4,499 for the 16-inch, S$6,299 and **S$6,499** for the M5 Max pair.[1]

The silicon is not new. M5 Pro and M5 Max are the chips Apple shipped in March, and the standard 14-inch M5 Pro still starts at **S$2,999**. So the step up is **S$1,000** on the 14-inch and **S$1,200** on the Max — and what it buys is the panel, the touch layer and about 220 grams. The display is tandem OLED at **2,000 nits** peak for HDR and SDR alike, **ten million to one** contrast, ProMotion from 10Hz to 120Hz, and P3 and Adobe RGB in a single default preset.[1]

The rest is subtraction and addition in the usual proportions. The 14-inch is **three pounds**, half a pound lighter; the 16-inch four, and nearly a millimetre thinner. Battery life is up to **24 hours** on Apple's own September testing. The notch becomes a **Dynamic Island**, the hinge was redesigned so the screen moves less when poked, and storage runs to **16TB**. Apple will sell the touch and non-touch lines side by side.[1]

S$1,000

THE SINGAPORE STEP FROM THE STANDARD 14-INCH MACBOOK PRO TO THE TOUCH ONE. THE PROCESSOR IN BOTH IS THE SAME CHIP APPLE SHIPPED IN MARCH[1]

THE CHATTER · FOURTEEN THOUSAND DOLLARS, CONFIGURED

The only substantive Hacker News thread, posted by **sumnole** on 29 October, ran under the headline "Apple's New Touchscreen MacBook Pro Costs Up to **$14,549**" — driven largely by a **$7,000** storage option. **musicale**, drily: "Such a bargain. But you know they're going to sell almost all of the M5 Max 128GB that they can make." **cyanydeez** did the arithmetic that matters to a home-lab reader: "Thats approxly 2 strix halo 495 with 192GB each."[2]

THE SCEPTIC · NOBODY HAS MEASURED THE FP2

A week after Sigma announced the **fp2**, after a full review and a team video, there is still **no published readout figure in milliseconds and no measured rolling-shutter value** anywhere this desk can find. The only hard proxy remains the **1/50 second** flash sync, unchanged since Tuesday's issue, on a camera with electronic shutter only and no stabilisation. Treat any claim that the rolling shutter is "tamed" as unsourced until a laboratory prints a number.[3]

STILL ON THE SHELF

Sigma's own newsroom dates the fp2 to 23 October, ships it on 11 November and prints no list price in Japan at all — the page says *open price*. The US body is **US$2,199**, or $2,749 with the EVF-21 or the 50mm F2; 24.5MP partially stacked, 20fps, 70GB onboard, 460g. **No Singapore price or distributor has been published.**[3]

Fujifilm gave the Instax mini Evo 2 a sensor more than three times larger and took away two colours. Announced 27 October at **US$290**, on sale end of November, black only. The sensor goes from 6.3 to **20.6 square millimetres**, the rear screen from three inches to a **4.5-inch** touchscreen covering the back, and the physical buttons are gone. Fisheye and Mirror effects are out. **No Singapore price announced.**[4]

The iPad mini closed the thread it opened in No. 145. Announced 26 October: **S$999** Wi-Fi, S$1,229 cellular, 8.5-inch OLED at 1,200 nits, A20 Pro on a two-nanometre process, 5.4mm, and — the part that was missing — a published **IP67** rating. The Galaxy Buds On still have neither an IP rating nor a Singapore price.[5]

SOURCES 1 Apple's own newsroom releases of 28 October 2026, US and Singapore editions, for prices, dates and specifications; the standard 14-inch comparison price from Apple Singapore's March 2026 release. **Apple publishes no resolution for the PROLED panel and none is printed here.** 2 Hacker News item 50283162, by signed username, 29 October 2026. 3 Sigma's own Japanese newsroom entry of 23 October and DPReview's full review of the same date; the absence of a measurement is this desk's search of the review, the maker's page and the measurement forums. 4 DPReview, 27 October 2026. 5 Apple Singapore's newsroom release of 26 October 2026. **Reddit, the MacRumors forums, the DPReview forums and Head-Fi all refused this desk, so every community line above is from Hacker News, which did not.**

THE GOOD LIFE · THE LAST COLLABORATION

Habring² and SJX priced their final collaboration at US$28,500 for thirty watches

The Chrono Felix Perpetual "Star", published on 29 October, is a 38.5mm steel monopusher with a perpetual-calendar module, a 40 per cent deposit and deliveries from January 2027.

The **Habring² × SJX Chrono Felix Perpetual "Star"** was published on Thursday **29 October** by SJX in Singapore and by Monochrome in Europe the same day — the third and final collaboration between the Austrian workshop and the Singapore watch title. Thirty pieces, each numbered on the caseback, at **US$28,500 before taxes**, ordered direct from SJX with a **40 per cent** deposit and deliveries from **January 2027**.[1]

The specification is unusually restrained for the money. Steel, **38.5mm** across and **13mm** high with the crystal, a triple-stepped bezel, domed anti-reflective sapphire front and back, and **30 metres** of water resistance. Inside is the **calibre A11CP**: hand-wound, 21 jewels, 30mm wide, **4Hz**, a **48-hour** reserve — Habring²'s own A11 monopusher chronograph base under a Dubois-Dépraz perpetual-calendar module, with the chronograph pusher doubling as the day corrector.[1]

The dial is where the edition earns its name: black lacquer, gold-plated hands, a gold moon disc at twelve, and **eight applied gold stars** standing in for hour indexes. Monochrome's **Brice Goulard** calls Habring² "one of the best-kept secrets on the indie scene" and concedes what the bezel is doing: the stepped profile masks the height the module adds, "one of the compromises that Habring² has to make by working with a module".[1]

For a Singapore reader this is a local purchase with no local number. SJX is Singapore-based and is the sole channel, but the price is quoted in dollars **before taxes** and **no SGD figure is published anywhere**. Budget for GST on the landed value and ask at the order.[1]

Thirty

PIECES OF THE FINAL HABRING²–SJX COLLABORATION, AT US$28,500 EACH BEFORE TAXES, ORDERED DIRECT ON A 40 PER CENT DEPOSIT[1]

THE CHATTER · LAUNCHED TO SILENCE

Monochrome's piece on the "Star" carried a reply box and **no replies at all** at the time of reading — a US$28,500 independent perpetual released into quiet. Where the forums did speak was Armin Strom's repeater: on WatchProSite, **amanico**, "As impressive as is its price", answered by **enjoythemusic** with "Being a multi-millionaire is pedestrian numbers my friend" — though that exchange dates from April, not this week.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · TWO WEEKS, STILL NO MEASUREMENT

This desk searched Audio Science Review's own forum index on 29 October for **ATH-AWX7000** and for **Audio-Technica AWX7000**. Both returned **"No results found"**. A fortnight after a **US$3,799** flagship headphone went on sale in three regions, the measurement community has not produced a single thread on it. And A. Lange & Söhne published a new Datograph Perpetual on 24 October — **50 pieces, platinum, 41mm, 0.13 carats of baguette markers, a movement and case unchanged since 2006** — and priced it, for the fourth issue running, "on request".[3]

ELSEWHERE ON THE SHELF

Armin Strom put CHF 390,000 on a minute repeater that will chime 12:59 on command. The Resonance 12:59 First Edition, published 26 October, is titanium, 42mm, **25 pieces**, Westminster carillon on four hammers — and push the slide *down* and it strikes twelve fifty-nine whatever the time, a dial dot turning red to show it armed.[4]

JBL put US$9,999 a pair on the L150 Classic and showed it in Warsaw. A three-way floorstander with a **15-inch** pulp woofer, crossovers at 310Hz and 1.8kHz, rated to 33Hz. It is due in 2027 with no ship date, no dealer allocation and no Singapore price — and **no sensitivity, impedance, power handling or full frequency response disclosed.**[5]

SOURCES 1 SJX's own announcement of 29 October 2026 and Monochrome's of the same day, read at both sites; the two agree on the price and the edition size and differ slightly on the delivery months, so the earliest is printed. 2 Monochrome's comment box, read 29 October; WatchProSite's Armin Strom thread, **dated April 2026 and labelled as such here rather than passed off as this week's sentiment.** 3 Audio Science Review's own forum search, run twice on 29 October 2026; the Lange reference from SJX, 24 October. 4 SJX, 26 October 2026; **the 250-second tolerance is single-sourced to SJX and no independent measurement was found.** 5 CE Pro, 27 October 2026, reporting the Audio Video Show debut of 23–25 October. **Hodinkee's comments and Head-Fi were unreachable; Steinway Lyngdorf's Model O is "price on application" and dealer listings disagree by more than fifty per cent, so no figure for it appears here.**

SCREEN & SOUND · THE SECOND WEEKEND

Fielder and Oppenheim's Holmes documentary grew 25% in weekend two to $19.5m

A24's You Can See Everything has taken $45.1m in ten days, from 855 sites to 2,655, at 97 per cent from 195 critics.

A24's *You Can See Everything*, Nathan Fielder and Lance Oppenheim's two-hour-fifty-four-minute film about Elizabeth Holmes, took **$19.5m** across the weekend of **23–25 October — 25 per cent more than its own opening weekend** — for a ten-day domestic total of **$45,145,476**. Box Office Mojo and The Numbers give identical figures. In the same chart, Street Fighter fell 72 per cent.[1]

It did it while more than tripling its footprint, from **855** sites to **2,655**, which is the part that ought not to work: a wider release normally dilutes the per-screen average. This one finished the weekend at **$7,344** a screen, the highest in the top ten and above the number-one film's $6,941.[1]

The reviews are at a level that invites suspicion. Rotten Tomatoes has it at **97 per cent from 195 critics**; Metacritic has **97 from 41 — 40 positive, one mixed, none negative**, the mixed notice being Time's, at 60. On Letterboxd, **theo**, at four and a half stars, writes the sharpest line on the method: "never has a documentary felt so much like everyone was acting."[2]

$7,344

PER-SCREEN AVERAGE FOR A TWO-HOUR-FIFTY-FOUR-MINUTE DOCUMENTARY IN ITS SECOND WEEKEND — HIGHER THAN THE WEEK'S NUMBER-ONE FILM[1]

THE CHATTER · SETTING THE RECORD STRAIGHT

A correction to No. 147. This desk printed *Clayface* at **59 critics against 94 audience**, and No. 145 at 76 per cent against 59. Both were captured while the count was still moving. Read again on 29 October, Rotten Tomatoes has the film at **77 per cent from 193 critics** against a Popcornmeter of **94 from more than 2,500** — the critic base has more than tripled and the score has settled. The audience gap, which was the point of the item, stands; the critics' number this magazine printed does not.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · THE AUDIENCE IS NOISIER THAN THE CRITICS

Against a Metascore of 97 with no negative reviews, Metacritic's own user panel logs **23 negative ratings out of 231** — ten per cent — for a user score of 8.4. And the claim circulating that this is the **second-biggest documentary opening in North American history**, behind *Fahrenheit 9/11*'s $23.9m, together with the **$7m budget**, comes from a single outlet attributing both to unnamed "reports". Neither could be verified at Box Office Mojo or The Numbers, and both are printed here as claims.[4]

ALSO THIS WEEK

Chai Vasarhelyi and Jimmy Chin's *Everest: The Other Side* opens wide today through Disney, at **83 per cent from 18 critics** and a Metascore of **63 from 16 — ten positive, six mixed**. The spread is the story: Film Threat 100, Variety 50, The Playlist 42. **The audience score is zero ratings**, because nobody has seen it yet.[5]

Taika Waititi's *Klara and the Sun* quadrupled its per-screen average and stayed at 24 per cent. This magazine reported **$198 a screen** and nought of 26 positive reviews on Wednesday. On 880 screens it took **$701,059**, or **$797** a screen, and the critics' score is now **24 per cent from 86** — against an audience score of **75**.[6]

Ella Langley returned to number one on the Hot 100 dated 31 October, with "Choosin' Texas" rising two to one in its **53rd week** on the chart; Billboard's own chart report calls it a record-extending 25th week at the top. Tate McRae's "Housewife" entered at **two**, her highest as a lead artist, and Zach Bryan with Lana Del Rey at **four**.[7]

SOURCES 1 Box Office Mojo's weekend chart for 2026W43 and The Numbers' chart for the weekend of 23 October, both read 29 October 2026 and in agreement; **Box Office Mojo labels the chart estimates.** 2 Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic, both read 29 October; Letterboxd for the two signed reviews. 3 Rotten Tomatoes' *Clayface* page, read 29 October 2026, against this magazine's own Nos. 145 and 147. 4 Metacritic's user panel; the opening-record and budget claims from The Week, 24 October, which attributes them to unnamed reports. 5 Box Office Mojo's calendar for 30 October; Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic, 29 October. 6 Rotten Tomatoes and The Numbers, 29 October. 7 Billboard's Canadian edition of the Hot 100 dated 31 October 2026, read 29 October; **the weeks-at-number-one total is Billboard's own chart-beat framing and is not published on the chart page itself. billboard.com's album charts return a payment wall, so no first-week album figure appears in this issue.**

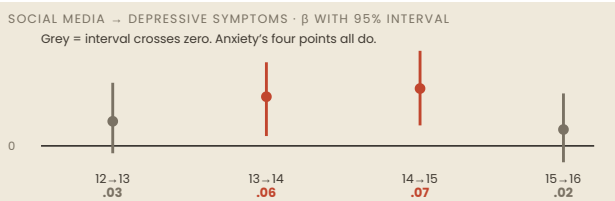
THE FAMILY DESK · THE WINDOW AT THIRTEEN

Jason Nagata's ABCD cohort puts the depression link at thirteen, not twelve

Jason Nagata's five-wave analysis of 11,279 children in the ABCD study puts the effect at β .06 by fourteen — and finds nothing at all for anxiety, in any year.

The American Academy of Pediatrics' journal *Pediatrics* published online on **19 October** a five-wave analysis by **Jason M. Nagata** and colleagues at the University of California, San Francisco, of **11,279** children in the Adolescent Brain Cognitive Development study, mean age **12.01** at baseline. It asks whether problematic social-media use and depressive symptoms predict each other — and finds that they do, but not yet.[1]

At the transition this reader's household is standing on, there is nothing. From year two to year three — roughly twelve to thirteen — social-media use predicts later depressive symptoms at **β .03, confidence interval −.009 to .077**, and depression predicts later use at **−.01**. Both intervals cross zero. The following year they do not: **.06** each way at thirteen to fourteen, and **.07** at fourteen to fifteen, before returning to null at fifteen to sixteen.[1]



The coefficient, wave by wave, from the paper's own Table 1. A twelve-year-old stands at the left-hand end. *Meridian* original.

Anxiety gets nothing anywhere. All eight cross-lagged anxiety paths are non-significant across five years, the largest at .04 — in the authors' words, associations with anxiety "were not observed". Note also **who is answering**: the social-media measure is the child's own report on a six-item scale, while depression and anxiety are **parent-reported** on the Child Behavior Checklist. The authors say so themselves: caregivers "may underrecognize internalizing symptoms that are less observable". The paper reports **no p-values** for these paths at all.[1]

THE CHATTER · THE POOLING ARGUMENT

Nature Human Behaviour published a counterweight eleven days earlier: **Tong Gong** and colleagues at the Karolinska Institutet, **21,797** Swedish twins, where a hazard ratio of **3.37** across all twins fell to **1.65** within discordant pairs — and did not survive the study's own multiple-comparison threshold. Gong: "Our results suggest that the association may in some cases have been overestimated." Against that, **Jonathan Haidt** and **Zach Rausch** argued on 20 October that pooled analyses "combine heterogeneous exposures… and then treat weak aggregate associations as evidence that specific risks are negligible".[2]

THE SCEPTIC · THE CRITIC IS A CO-AUTHOR

Candice Odgers of UC Irvine is the standing "don't be alarmist" voice in this literature, and she is not a bystander: she is a named co-author of the Icelandic school phone-ban paper this magazine reported on Thursday, which found that bans "were not associated with meaningful changes in adolescent mental health". Her declared interest belongs in the same sentence: **she sits on YouTube's Youth and Families Advisory Committee**. The effect sizes above are small in absolute terms and the authors say so.[3]

THE MONTH'S OTHER EVIDENCE

And one study stratified by age, on exactly this band. *Behavioural Sciences*, 14 October: **6,125** Chinese adolescents, with an early-adolescent subgroup of **2,994 aged twelve to fourteen**. Heavy *entertainment* use against light was worth **2.08 points on the GAD-7** at a Bonferroni-adjusted p below .001, and **age moderated the effect, strongest at twelve to fourteen**. *Information-seeking* use did nothing at all: F(1,3034) = 0.47, p = 0.492. It is cross-sectional, and the authors say the causation may run the other way.[4]

The largest synthesis yet is an umbrella review of 23 meta-analyses covering 2,817,252 children in 64 countries, published in JAMA *Pediatrics* on 28 September by Sheri Madigan's Calgary group. Converted to correlations: academic achievement **r −0.15**, language −0.14, internalising 0.10, externalising 0.11 — and **null for executive function, mathematics, science and reading**. Age moderated several of them.[4]

SOURCES 1 *Pediatrics*, published online 19 October 2026, doi 10.1542/peds.2025-075060, read in full at PubMed Central; funding NIH K08HL159350 and the Doris Duke Charitable Foundation, both to Nagata. **A co-author, Dimitri Christakis, is a paid expert witness in social-media litigation and edits a rival journal; the paper declares it.** 2 *Nature Human Behaviour*, 8 October 2026, doi 10.1038/s41562-026-02607-0, and Karolinska's own release; Haidt and Rausch in *Perspectives on Psychological Science*, 20 October 2026, doi 10.1177/17456916261482033. **The twin study has no twelve-year-old wave at all — it measures at nine, fifteen, eighteen and twenty-four.** 3 *JAMA Network Open* 2026;9(10):e2640893, read at PubMed Central, including the competing-interest statement. 4 *JAMA Pediatrics*, published online 28 September 2026, doi 10.1001/jamapediatrics.2026.4339. **Reddit was unreachable, so no parent-forum line appears on this desk.**

THE TWEEN YEARS · WHAT A RULE BUYS

PLOS Digital Health finds strict screen rules buy 56 minutes a day

Daniel Lopez and Bonnie Nagel's analysis of 8,089 ABCD families, published 28 October, says the gain erodes by thirteen minutes for every year of age.

PLOS Digital Health published on **28 October** an analysis by **Daniel A. Lopez** and **Bonnie J. Nagel** at Oregon Health & Science University of **8,089** families in the ABCD study, average age about thirteen. It measures what a household rule actually buys — in self-report, in passively logged phone minutes and in keystrokes — and how fast the purchase depreciates.[1]

High restriction against low is worth **56.0 fewer minutes a day** of total screen time, **43.5** fewer smartphone minutes by self-report, **79.3** fewer by the passive Android measurement, and **286** fewer keystrokes. Moderate restriction buys far less: **11.5** minutes, and its keystroke effect does not survive correction. Then the decay term: the high-restriction advantage shrinks by **13.0 minutes a day for each year of the child's age**.[1]

Parents give up, and it is measurable. Membership of the high-restriction profile runs **46.9 per cent** at year three, **35.2** at year four and **25.3** at year five; low restriction moves the other way, **14.4** to **36.1**. Only one family in ten stayed low throughout, and about one in five stayed high. Against which: the model explains roughly **a tenth** of the variance in screen time, with a test R^2 of 0.1022 and a mean absolute error of over two hours.[1]

The single most useful number for a Singapore household is which rule carried the weight. Ranked by the model's own importance scores, it is not a time limit: it is **a screen-based device playing in the room as the child falls asleep (0.23)** and **falling asleep while using a device (0.21)**. Limiting weekend screen time scores 0.10, and access to a mobile device in bed 0.06.[1]

46.9 → 25.3%

SHARE OF FAMILIES IN THE STRICTEST PROFILE AT YEAR THREE AND AT YEAR FIVE. THE RULE DECAYS FASTER THAN THE CHILD DOES[1]

THE CHATTER · SINGAPORE WILL NOT COPY AUSTRALIA

Singapore's Ministry of Digital Development and Information published a factsheet on **23 October** drawn from engagements with over **2,000** parents and young people. **More than 80 per cent of parents and nearly 70 per cent of youth backed tiered, age-based access; neither group wanted an outright ban.** On preferred default safeguards: disable autoplay **76**, disable direct messaging **75**, a daily time limit **75**. Legislation comes in **2027**, on two tracks — effective age assurance, and safer-by-design teen features.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · THE PHONE IS NOT THE VARIABLE

Sleep Health published on **10 October** a study of **1,510** children **aged eleven to thirteen** — the band that actually contains a Secondary One pupil — and found that **owning a smartphone was associated with lower odds of insufficient sleep and of trouble sleeping**. What raised the odds was the phone in hand or in bed at night, using it in bed, posting publicly, more than two hours of evening use, and exposure to cyberbullying, which predicted every adverse outcome. Using it in bed was strongest, at odds ratios reported up to thirteen.[3]

ELSEWHERE, THE MINIMUM AGE MOVES

Türkiye's minimum age of fifteen takes effect tomorrow. New users must be verified through the state e-Devlet portal with a token confirming only the threshold, not identity; existing accounts have until **31 March 2027**. **Greece** set the same age with no parental-consent exemption, using 1 January as the reference birth date, from **1 January 2027**. **Both are single-sourced to one trade outlet and neither gazette could be read** — printed as reported, not as law.[4]

General guidance, not medical advice. If one thing on this page is worth acting on tonight, it is the top of that importance ranking, and it costs nothing: the device leaves the bedroom at lights-out.

SOURCES 1 *PLOS Digital Health* 2026;5(10):e0001127, doi 10.1371/journal.pdig.0001127, published 28 October 2026 and read in full at the journal. The authors received no specific funding; a senior author is an ABCD principal investigator at her own institution, which the paper declares. **Passive measurement was available only for an Android subset, and high restriction was more common in higher-income, better-educated households.** 2 Singapore's Ministry of Digital Development and Information, its own factsheet of 23 October 2026. 3 *Sleep Health*, 10 October 2026, doi 10.1016/j.sleh.2026.09.012; **the journal's publisher refused this desk, so the per-behaviour odds ratios and intervals behind that figure were not read.** 4 Biometric Update, 12 and 14 October 2026, citing Türkiye Today and Greek outlets; **no gazette number, official instrument or parliamentary record was located for either, and the Greek vote outcome is unconfirmed.**

THE MACRO DESK · THE PAUSE AND THE PRINT

Warsh's Fed held, then September PCE accelerated to 3.6% and GDP printed 3.4%

The committee voted ten to two on 28 October, with Lisa Cook and Beth Hammack dissenting to raise; a month ago the market put a December increase below one chance in ten.

The Federal Open Market Committee held its target range at **3.75 to 4.00 per cent** on Wednesday **28 October**, ten votes to two, with **Lisa D. Cook** and **Beth M. Hammack** both preferring a quarter-point rise. The statement calls activity "expanding at a strong pace", inflation "elevated", and closes with a sentence no recent committee has used: **"The Committee will deliver price stability."**[1]

The implementation note is the part worth reading twice. The directive instructs the Desk, "when appropriate", to **increase System Open Market Account holdings through purchases of Treasury bills**, and to reinvest all agency principal into bills, "continuing its policy of maintaining ample reserves". So the price of money is restrictive and the quantity is being added to. This is not a liquidity-tight front end.[1]

Then the data landed, the next morning, together. The Bureau of Economic Analysis put third-quarter growth at **3.4 per cent** annualised against 2.2 in the second, and September's consumption deflator at **plus 3.6 per cent on the year**, up from 3.4 in August, with core at **3.1**. On 26 October the market had priced another increase **below ten per cent**. Three days later it was above eighty.[2]

> *"The Committee will deliver price stability."*

The cause is one shock in three currencies. Brent settled at **$115.32** on 28 October, **up about 18 per cent on the month and 80 on the year** after attacks on shipping near Hormuz. That has carried American headline inflation to 3.6, the euro area's to **3.8** with energy at **18.9**, and Australia's to **4.3**. Three central banks, one price — and beneath it a labour market the hawks are overriding: September payrolls **plus 29,000** and earnings **plus 3.0 per cent**, so real wages are falling.[3]

THE LEVELS · AT THURSDAY'S CLOSE

US 10-year[4]	4.98%	▼ 7bp
US 2-year[4]	4.61%	▼ 6bp
VWRA	$191.28	▼ 0.19%
BNDW	$66.76	▲ 0.23%
Gold	$4,021.33	▼ 1.14%
Bitcoin	$79,097	▼ 2.60%
STI	5,396.03	▼ 0.03%

The move was in **real** yields — the ten-year real fell to **2.63**, leaving a breakeven of **2.35**. USD/SGD closed 1.2800. Explanation, not advice.[4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE FOUR

Name the regime: **higher-for-longer, supply-shock inflation, a hiking cycle paused rather than ended, with ample reserves at the front end.** The binding constraint on a global-equity-and-global-bond portfolio is not earnings — both legs price off one oil-driven variable, which is why the hedge is impaired. **Gold** fell 3.3 per cent on the month *while* its opportunity cost fell 13 basis points: the haven bid went to Treasuries. **Bitcoin** trades as a high-beta Nasdaq expression, not a liquidity asset.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · HIKING INTO A SUPPLY SHOCK

Lance Roberts takes the other side of the broken-diversification call: "Bonds do NOT hedge inflation. They hedge the slowdown that bad inflation eventually causes" — headline CPI went 2.4 to 3.7 while core moved only 2.5 to 2.6. He is adding duration. The harder dissent is **Ed Dowd**'s: "Hiking into a supply shock is rarely the right medicine". The tell that nobody owns this call: the odds moved from under ten to over eighty in three days.[6]

HIGHER-FOR-LONGER · SUPPLY-SHOCK INFLATION · AMPLE RESERVES

SOURCES 1 The Federal Reserve's own statement of 28 October 2026 and the implementation note published with it; the chairmanship from the Board's biographies page, the statement naming no chair. 2 The Bureau of Economic Analysis's advance third-quarter estimate and its September personal income and outlays release, both 29 October; the hike-odds readings from the World Gold Council, 26 October, and market commentary of the 29th. 3 Brent from The National and a commercial feed; the euro area from the ECB's own statement; Australia from its statistical agency, 28 October; payrolls from the Bureau of Labor Statistics. 4 The US Treasury's own daily par and real yield curves. **The breakeven is this desk's arithmetic from those two curves, not a quoted series; gold, bitcoin and the index levels come from a feed that labels its quotes derived rather than official, so weekly changes are withheld rather than interpolated. The Bank of Japan decides after this page closes.** 5 World Gold Council, 19 and 26 October and its August central-bank statistics. 6 Lance Roberts, 24 October 2026, and Ed Dowd, 21 September — **dated and labelled, the latter's figures his own and uncited.**

THE RABBIT HOLE · GLIDING AND SOARING

James Payne took a sailplane to 22,657 metres over Argentina with no engine

Gliding runs on four kinds of rising air. A modern eighteen-metre racer was measured at 57 to 1 by Idaflieg, and the straight-distance record is 3,008 kilometres.

On **2 September 2018**, over El Calafate in Argentina, **James M. Payne** flew an engineless aircraft to **22,657 metres** — 74,334 feet, in a mountain wave. That is the outer edge of a sport whose central fact is simple: a glider is always descending through the air around it, at perhaps **half a metre a second**, and the whole art is finding air that is going up faster than that.[1]

There are four kinds, and each has a price of entry. **Thermals** are bubbles of air heated off uneven ground; climbs of several metres a second are common, and in flat country they run past **3,000 metres**. **Ridge lift** is wind deflected up a hillside: it needs **20 to 25 knots** and works to about twice the height of the hill. **Wave** is the standing oscillation downwind of a mountain range, marked by lenticular cloud, triggered by about **25 knots** across the ridge — and it is what takes a sailplane into the stratosphere. **Convergence**, where two air masses meet, works on as little as **10 knots**.[1]

The hard currency is the glide ratio, and it is measured, not claimed. The German research consortium **Idaflieg** put a **Jonker JS3** at eighteen metres at about **57 to 1** in flight test; its chief aerodynamicist **Johan Bosman** says the earlier JS1 reached 53. A Schleicher ASG 29 publishes **50** and a minimum sink of **0.47 metres a second**. Competition pilots average around **120 km/h** over tasks of up to a thousand kilometres; the record average over 1,000km is **203.1 km/h**, the straight-distance record **3,008 km**.[1]

The hook is not the record. Ask the pilots and it is the first solo, then the first three hundred kilometres — and they are unusually honest about the cost. **Scott Fletcher**, on the Usenet group where this sport still argues with itself in full sentences: **"You are probably going to suck at it for bit longer than you are comfortable with."** He puts it at a year to the licence and two more to learn cross-country. **Roy Bourgeois** names the sales problem exactly: to an outsider gliding looks like "an extended slide to the ground".[2]

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MEMBERS OF THE VICTORIAN SOARING ASSOCIATION IN JULY 2026, AGAINST **667** IN JUNE 2018 — THE FRESHEST HARD MEMBERSHIP SERIES PUBLISHED ANYWHERE IN THE SPORT[3]

THE CHATTER · NOBODY CAN COUNT THE SPORT

The only world figure anyone cites — about **111,000** active glider pilots and **32,920** gliders — rests on **2011** statistics. The Soaring Society of America's own pages disagree with each other, one saying "almost 10,000" members and the directory reading **8,604**. American glider pilots flew an average of **102,412 hours a year** from 1999 to 2021, against a 2002 peak of **157,831**. The British Gliding Association counts **73 clubs** and **2,116 aircraft** — and qualified more instructors in 2024 than in any year of the previous decade.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · RECRUITMENT IS NOT RETENTION

The Victorian Soaring Association put the whole problem in one sentence in August, and it is the most useful line in this issue: **"The loss of 100 members over eight years cannot be solved through recruitment alone. For example, if 100 people are recruited but a similar number leave, the organisation remains at the same level."** Its numbers say the funnel is not the failure: women are **11.8 per cent** of members and about **28 per cent** of trial-flight passengers. The British association names the same thing more quietly — "the relatively high age demographic… numbers naturally retiring from the sport remaining of significant concern".[3]

WHAT THE NEXT TWO PAGES DESCEND INTO

The gear, which has a price problem: not one European factory publishes a list price. **The economics**, which do not: a winch launch is £8.50 and a week at Benalla AUD $3,850. **The badge ladder**, unchanged since 1930. **And starting from Singapore**, where there is no gliding at all.

SOURCES 1 The FAI record lists for the altitude and distance marks; the lift mechanisms, climb rates and speed figures from the standard reference articles on soaring lift and on gliding; the Idaflieg measurement and Bosman's remarks from Jonker Sailplanes' own account of the 2020 flight-test camp, published 5 February 2021; ASG 29 figures from the type's published data. **Perlan's own page puts its next El Calafate campaign in 2027, single-sourced.** 2 The thread "Why is Soaring Declining?", started by Brian Nightingale on 19 November 2025 and running to 2,237 views, read at its Google Groups archive; quotations by signed name and date. 3 The Victorian Soaring Association's membership and participation analysis of August 2026, data supplied by Gliding Australia; the Soaring Safety Foundation's FY24 report for the American hours series; the British Gliding Association's 2024 annual report. **The world total is a 2011 figure and is printed as such; no current one exists anywhere this desk could reach, and the BGA's own site refused every request, so its report was read from a mirror.**

Begin with the finding that organises the whole gear question: **not one European sailplane factory publishes a price.** Schleicher directs buyers to a sales address for "additional information about equipment options by providing a quotation". Schempp-Hirth lists no specification, price or lead time; its own Retrofit Solutions menu entry is empty. DG Aviation's only lead-time language is that "delays can occur". Jonker has a Get Your Offer form; GP Gliders says "price upon request"; Lange says nothing. Every euro figure circulating online is a decade old, a dealer's used ask, or an aggregator's invention.[1]

So the honest ladder is a used one, and it is wide. A Schleicher **ASW-20**, the classic first single-seater, trades at **US$20,000 to $45,000** on a broker's own 2023-based valuation; a **Ventus 2c** was asked at **$95,000** and a **Discus 2c** at **$199,000**. A nearly new **Discus 2c FES** sold at **$195,000**, its seller noting that was "about what you would pay for a new order". **These are undated dealer listings from a site that refused this desk machine access — a shape, not a quotation.**[2]

Two things genuinely changed in the last twelve months, and only two. The first is that **electric self-launch crossed from novelty to certified product line**. Schempp-Hirth's **Ventus 3E Sport** took EASA certification in mid-2025; the **Performance** version flew on 18 November 2025 — **39 kilowatts**, airborne in about **300 metres**, climbing to **2,500** plus roughly **100km** of bridging reserve — and was certificated in August. Schleicher's **AS 35 Mi** flew in November 2025 and got its type certificate in **August 2026**; design engineer **Paul Anklam** calls it "a grown-up AS 33". And on **17 September** came a **Duo Discus FES** — an electric sustainer on the standard club two-seater, which is the quiet news.[3]

The second is a bill, not a product. **Electronic conspicuity mandates arrived in three jurisdictions at once.** The American regulator published an advance notice that would remove the transponder exemption for gliders, citing about **45 near-collisions between 1988 and 2014** and a 2006 mid-air in which the glider's transponder had been switched off to save battery. Britain's authority consulted through September, and the **BGA, BMAA and BHPA** jointly opposed blanket equipage, warning the proposed kit **"would not be compatible with EASA's ADS-L protocol"**. Switzerland now requires gliders to be electronically visible.[4]

For the reader who cares about instruments, the panel is where this sport keeps its precision. **LXNAV's S200**, the current flagship vario, is **US$2,390**: an 80mm round display, an integrated flight recorder, an inertial platform with an eight-g accelerometer and three gyros, a thermal assistant combining seven analysis methods, and a traffic mode that calls "HEAD ON" out loud. Its **HAWK** at **$1,310** runs an extended Kalman filter to estimate all three dimensions of air movement. A full panel — LX9070 with a V8 at **$5,990**, HAWK, a PowerMouse at $2,050, a Nano⁴ at $830 — is **$10,180** before a transponder; a Trig TT23 is another **$2,995**.[5]

THE CHATTER · THE FREE ONE IS THE INTERESTING ONE

XCSoar is open source and costs nothing: moving map with terrain and airspace, thermal assistant, FLARM and Open Glider Network traffic — and it reads **Condor 3 telemetry**, so a home simulator can drive a real glide computer. It runs on Android, iOS, macOS, Linux, Windows and, for the determined, on **Kobo e-readers**. Current stable is **7.46**, and the project publishes no release dates.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · TEN MONTHS ON THE GROUND

The counterweight to the Jonker story is a grounding. EASA issued an emergency airworthiness directive against the **JS3 RES** engine system, and owners sat for **roughly ten months** until the agency approved a major change on **16 April 2026**. The newest open-class ship, the **JS5 Rey**, uses no battery at all: Jonker chose a **50-kilowatt fuel-injected petrol** sustainer. At the top of the class, 2026's answer was a better engine.[6]

WHAT A GLIDER ACTUALLY COSTS TO OWN

A quarter share is how most people own one: a quarter of a $40,000 ASW-20-class ship is about **$10,000**, plus a quarter of trailer, hangarage, insurance and annual. **The trailer is the hidden tier and nobody will quote it** — each is built to one aircraft with a type-specific axle position, so used Cobras at **$13,000 to $15,750** are the only anchors. A parachute is **$3,885**; oxygen for wave flying **$1,105**; a one-person rigging aid **$2,400**, the purchase that decides whether you fly on a Tuesday.[7]

SOURCES 1 The manufacturers' own websites, all read 29 October 2026 — Alexander Schleicher, Schempp-Hirth, DG Aviation, Jonker Sailplanes, GP Gliders and Lange Aviation. 2 A broker-aggregator's valuation page, which states its data is 2023-based, and dealer listings reached through search extracts. **The principal American dealer refused machine access.** 3 Schempp-Hirth's and Schleicher's own news pages; the Ventus 3E Performance maiden-flight figures from WeGlide Magazine, 28 November 2025. **A search of the published type certificates did not surface a Performance-specific entry, so that certification is the maker's own announcement.** 4 The American notice via Aviation International News, April 2026; the British joint statement and the Swiss requirement from the regulators' own pages. **FLARM's site refused this desk, so no maker's response appears.** 5 Cumulus Soaring's catalogue, read 29 October 2026 — **the only fully priced price list in world gliding, and it is one man in Minnesota**; XCSoar's own site. 6 Jonker Sailplanes' own news archive, entries of 1 and 6 May and 14 February 2026. 7 Prices as above; the share arithmetic is this desk's, from the listed asking prices.

The culture divides on how you get off the ground, and it is an economic argument wearing a national costume. Britain winches: Cotswold charges **£16** a launch from May, Devon and Somerset **£10.40**, the Wolds **£8.50**, against **£26 to £35** for an aerotow to 2,000 feet. Australia tows and bills by the minute — Benalla at **AUD $9.25** a minute for members — with a winch available only on a trial rate to June. Germany is the winch heartland. The second fault line is Club class against Open: handicapped old airframes and skill on one side, twenty-four metres and euros on the other.[1]

The ladder a pilot climbs has not changed since **1930**. Silver is **1,000 metres of climb, five hours aloft and fifty kilometres** across country; Gold is **3,000 metres and 300 kilometres**; the three Diamonds are a declared 300km goal, **500km** in one flight and **5,000 metres** of height. Past that, diplomas begin at a thousand kilometres.[2]

What it costs is unusually transparent, because clubs publish fee schedules and factories do not. A full flying membership at Benalla is **AUD $595** if you volunteer and **$1,190** if you do not — the economics of the sport in one line, and the Usenet group says it out loud: cheap gliding "is due to the subsidy of free unskilled and skilled labour, provided by club members gratis". British clubs run **£212 to £824** a year and **instruction is free**.[3]

And the Singapore answer is a plane ticket. **There is no gliding in Singapore** — the body that comes up in a search flies radio-controlled models — and this desk found **no active full-size club in Malaysia** either, where the aero-sport federation is running a paragliding league. Indonesia has a historic club at **Pondok Cabe** whose status could not be confirmed; Japan has a real university scene at **Sekiyado** and **Itakura**. The costed options are south: Benalla's seven-day **A Flying Start** is **AUD $3,850**, including **60,000 feet of towing**, about thirty launches, membership, a logbook and a bucket hat — and some students solo inside the week.[4]

THE FIRST NINETY DAYS, FROM A FLAT IN SINGAPORE

Days 1–30, about US$300, go nowhere. A **Condor 3 XC licence is $120** and a Schuwirth glider stick **$295**; the full XC Basic kit is **$200**. **XCSoar is free and reads the simulator's telemetry**, so the home setup is a real glide computer talking to a real instrument panel. The FAA's own Glider Flying Handbook is free online. **Days 31–60:** book the week — Benalla at AUD $3,850, or Lake Keepit's at about **$3,000**. **Days 61–90:** either return on a month's visitor membership at **AUD $400** and grind at the Silver C, or find out whether mountain wave is the thing, at Omarama: Kahu Soaring's three-day course is **NZ$4,000** for nine hours in a DuoDiscus. **Buy no aircraft, parachute, oxygen set or trailer in the first ninety days.**[5]

THE CHATTER · WHERE THE SPORT ARGUES

The centre of gravity is the **Online Contest**: you upload the recorder's trace, software optimises it, and it is public. The champion is decided on a pilot's **best six flights worldwide**. One club's description is the most affectionate thing written about the sport: "simple, timely, reasonably fair, and free", a way to "document, scrutinize, and compare your flying with others worldwide" and, with some humour, "a way to brag". **WeGlide** is where factory news now breaks.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · THE LAUNCH IS WHAT KILLS YOU

Print the numbers. Europe recorded **ten fatal sailplane accidents and twelve deaths in 2024**, the lowest the regulator has logged in that domain, against **27** deaths in 2022. In America the Soaring Safety Foundation counted **21 accidents in FY24, a 91 per cent rise**, two of them fatal; the decade averages run from **45.6 a year in the 1980s to 21.0 now**. The phase breakdown is the part nobody expects: **ten of the twenty-one happened landing, six of those at an airport rather than in a field** — while the five launch accidents produced both deaths. Since 2021 **no fatal accident has occurred in the cruise**. And the foundation cannot get flight-hour data: "the community has been unable or unwilling to reliably submit flight hours."[7]

NEXT DESCENTS

Amateur perfumery — accords, absolutes and a regulated materials list, argued over by chemists and collectors alike.

Ikebana — rival Japanese schools, a licence ladder of their own, and shears that cost more than the flowers.

Track days & rally driving — the real car, the real helmet, and the economics of going sideways on gravel.

SOURCES 1 Published fee schedules at Cotswold, Devon & Somerset, Wolds, Benalla and Lake Keepit, all read 29 October 2026. 2 The FAI Sporting Code, Section 3; the British Gliding Association's 2024 annual report. 3 The Gliding Club of Victoria's schedule of charges signed 7 April 2026; British club pages and *Sailplane & Gliding*; the subsidy line from rec.aviation.soaring. 4 Searches of the Malaysian, Indonesian, Thai, Philippine and Japanese scenes, with the results stated as found; Benalla's own course page and schedule. **Its website and its fee PDF differ by forty-five dollars on the course price; the PDF figure is printed.** 5 Cumulus Soaring's catalogue; Lake Keepit's price page; Kahu Soaring's course list. 6 The Online Contest's own pages, a club's account of what posting means, and WeGlide Magazine. **Subscriber counts for the YouTube channels disagree wildly across trackers and none is printed.** 7 The European regulator's annual safety reviews for 2024 and 2025; the Soaring Safety Foundation's FY24 report, including its own statement about missing hours.

FITNESS · THE CURVE THAT DOES NOT FLATTEN

Mayo Clinic Proceedings finds fitness keeps paying past 44 ml/kg/min

A UK Biobank analysis of 10,462 adults puts fifteen-year survival between 39.3 and 77.4 per cent across the fitness range — while grip strength stops paying at the median of 32kg.

Mayo Clinic Proceedings published online on **8 October** a UK Biobank analysis by **Aitana Tur-Boned** and **Joaquín Calatayud** at the University of Valencia which does what most fitness-and-mortality papers decline to do: it models the whole dose-response curve with splines instead of cutting the sample into quintiles. **10,462** participants, mean age **60.0**, median follow-up **12.5 years**, **2,101** deaths.[1]

The cohort's median estimated VO2max was **27.9 ml/kg/min**, which many recreational runners in their forties are already above. Against that reference, **12.5** carried **59 per cent higher** mortality (1.28 to 1.98), and at **44.5** the hazard ratio was **0.71** (0.56 to 0.89), with risk "declining continuously without plateau". There is no point in the observed range at which more fitness stopped helping.[1]

Grip strength behaves differently, and that is the finding worth taking to the gym. At **12kg**, mortality was **37 per cent higher**; but the association was curvilinear and **plateaued at the cohort median of 32kg**, "with no further reduction beyond the reference". Grip is a floor test, not a dose-response lever. Fifteen-year survival ran from **39.3 to 77.4 per cent** across the fitness range — a **38.1-point** spread — against 21.9 points across grip.[1]

Three caveats belong in the same breath. The VO2max is **estimated from submaximal cycling, not measured**. The entire cohort is people who went on to be diagnosed with cancer, so this is not a general-population curve. And the mean age is **60.0**, two decades above a mid-forties reader. The paper reports **no p-values** at all.[1]

0.71 at 44.5

THE HAZARD RATIO AT THE TOP OF THE OBSERVED RANGE AGAINST THE COHORT MEDIAN OF 27.9 — STILL FALLING, WITH NO PLATEAU[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT IS GOOD, ACTUALLY

Alex Hutchinson, on the Trondheim study of everyone in that city aged seventy to seventy-seven, lands the sentence this page needs: **"all else being equal, intense exercise worked better"** at preserving VO2max. The calibration is sobering: those Norwegian septuagenarians ran about **31.5 to 35.2**, comparable, he notes, to American forty-somethings.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · SIGNIFICANT AND ACCEPTABLE AT ONCE

Humberto Carvalho of Lund argued in the *British Journal of Sports Medicine* on **14 October** that the binary verdict — significant or null — is the error, not the finding. Both items here demonstrate it: the curve above carries **no p-values at all**, and the watch below is **"significantly" wrong and simultaneously "acceptably" accurate** under its own field's threshold.[3]

THREE FINDINGS, NONE OF THEM COMFORTABLE

Your watch reads about 2.6 points high and promises a race seven and a half minutes faster than you will run it. Twenty adults took a Garmin Forerunner 265 through twelve weeks of half-marathon training against laboratory tests and a real race: **43.95 against 41.10** at baseline, **45.00 against 42.43** after twelve weeks — accuracy did **not** improve with wear time — and a predicted **129.97 minutes against 137.55** run. Error stayed under ten per cent, so the authors call it useful for **trends**.[4]

At 57, twelve weeks of lifting changed no muscle proteins. At 22 it changed 135. Auburn and CUNY put 17 younger men and 15 older through matched training — volume identical at p = 0.771 — and measured 2,106 proteins. Lean mass rose **2.73kg against 1.18**. Yet **81.5 per cent** of those 135 moved the same way in the older group: the authors call it a **compressed**, not an altered, adaptation. **A mid-forties reader sits between the two groups and is represented by neither.**[5]

General guidance, not medical advice.

SOURCES 1 *Mayo Clinic Proceedings*, published online 8 October 2026, doi 10.1016/j.mayocp.2026.09.023, read through the journal's own deposited record; funding from Spain's science ministry, grant FPU24/03315, recovered from grant metadata. **The publisher refused this desk, so the formal limitations and competing-interest statements were not read.** 2 Alex Hutchinson, *Sweat Science*, 1 September 2026. 3 *British Journal of Sports Medicine*, published online 14 October 2026, doi 10.1136/bjsports-2026-112159; **an editorial-format piece whose full text was not retrieved, so the argument is reconstructed from its own abstract record.** 4 *Journal of Medical Engineering & Technology*, published online 1 October 2026, doi 10.1080/03091902.2026.2741912. **No funding or competing-interest statement appears in the record.** 5 *Physiological Reports* 2026;14(19):e71141, doi 10.14814/phy2.71141, read at PubMed Central; the authors declare no conflicts. **Reddit was unreachable for a fifteenth issue, and no dated October statement from the usual longevity podcasters could be read at source, so neither appears.**

THE DIARY · THE NOVEMBER WINDOWS

Disney On Ice opens its Singapore presale on 4 November, general sale the 25th

The Kallang's own page already flags one seat tier as limited for a March 2027 run — and the Australian Open's early-bird pricing closes at 12.59pm on 30 November.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

7–8 Nov — **Pokémon RUN 3.0 Singapore Edition**
STADIUM ROAR, THE KALLANG · 4KM NON-COMPETITIVE, 7AM–2PM · **FESTIVAL ZONE FREE**; RUN FEE NOT PUBLISHED ON THE VENUE PAGE · "ALL AGES"

13–22 Nov — **Singapore Writers Festival · 29th edition**
VICTORIA THEATRE, THE ARTS HOUSE, NATIONAL GALLERY · FESTIVAL PASS **S$30, YOUTH PASS S$15**, BOTH COVERING 100+ PROGRAMMES · THE 20% EARLY BIRD EXPIRED 18 OCT

20–29 Nov — **Kalaa Utsavam · 25th edition**
ESPLANADE · FROM **S$29** TO S$57.20 · *PAATI'S SPICE KITCHEN* 21–22 NOV AND THE FREE *NOT QUITE MURUKKU* ARE THE FAMILY-TAGGED ONES

25 NOV — **Guns N' Roses · one night**
NATIONAL STADIUM, DOORS 6PM · GENERAL SALE WAS 20 MAR · **THE VENUE PAGE STILL SAYS "MORE DETAILS COMING SOON" AND LISTS THREE VIP TIERS WITHOUT PRICES** · TICKETED FROM AGE 6

17–22 Dec — ★ **BTS · World Tour ARIRANG, four nights**
NATIONAL STADIUM, 17, 19, 20 AND 22 DEC · **VIP S$388 DOWN TO CAT6 S$148** · GENERAL SALE CLOSED 5 JUNE · TICKETED FROM AGE 3

29–30 Jan — ★ **Kenshi Yonezu · GHOST World Tour**
SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM, 2027 · **GENERAL SALE OPENED 22 OCTOBER, AND A SECOND NIGHT OPENED ON THE 23RD** — TICKETS ARE LIVE NOW · **BUY SEATED: UNDER-12S ARE BARRED FROM THE STANDING PENS**

13–21 Mar — ★ **Disney On Ice presents *Let's Dance!***
SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM, 2027 · **PRIORITY GUEST PRESALE 4–24 NOV WITH 15% OFF CAT 1–4; GENERAL SALE 25 NOV, 10AM** · TICKETED FROM AGE 2; UNDER-12S NEED A TICKETED ADULT

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

28 Nov–5 May — ★ **Niseko United · 2026/27 season**
HOKKAIDO · **1-DAY ADULT ¥8,800 EARLY (28 NOV–11 DEC) AGAINST ¥13,500 PEAK (24 DEC–28 FEB)**; CHILD 4–12 ¥5,300 TO ¥8,100 · GRAND HIRAFU AND ANNUPURI RUN TO 5 MAY

20 Nov–14 Mar — **Sapporo White Illumination**
ODORI PARK AND EKIMAE-DORI · **FREE** · THE GERMAN CHRISTMAS MARKET RUNS 20 NOV–25 DEC

11–31 Jan — ★ **Australian Open 2027**
MELBOURNE PARK · GROUND PASSES **FROM A$49, EARLY-BIRD UNTIL 12.59PM 30 NOV** · **OPENING WEEK 11–16 JAN IS A$10 ADULT, A$5 KIDS, FREE FOR KIDS ON THE 11TH** · DAILY ALLOCATIONS CAPPED FOR THE FIRST TIME

4–11 Feb — ★ **Sapporo Snow Festival**
ODORI, SUSUKINO AND TSUDOME, 2027 · ODORI AND SUSUKINO **FREE** · THE OTARU SNOW LIGHT PATH FOLLOWS 6–13 FEB · **THE ENGLISH SITE STILL SHOWS 2025**

25–28 Feb — ★ **CP+ 2027 · camera and photo imaging show**
PACIFICO YOKOHAMA · **FREE WITH PRE-REGISTRATION, OPENING EARLY DECEMBER** · **DATES PRESS-REPORTED, NOT YET ON THE SHOW'S OWN PAGE**

14–28 Mar — **Grand Sumo · Haru Basho, Osaka**
2027 · **ADVANCE SALES OPEN SATURDAY 6 FEBRUARY** · THE NOVEMBER KYUSHU BASHO IS SOLD OUT ON ALL FIFTEEN DAYS, WITH NO SAME-DAY SALES

9–11 Apr — **Formula 1 Japanese Grand Prix**
SUZUKA CIRCUIT, 2027 · **WAITLIST ONLY** ON THE OFFICIAL PAGE, FOR GENERAL ADMISSION AND HOSPITALITY ALIKE

¥4,700

THE GAP BETWEEN A NISEKO DAY PASS IN THE OPENING FORTNIGHT AND THE SAME PASS AT CHRISTMAS — A 53 PER CENT PREMIUM FOR THE SCHOOL HOLIDAYS[1]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THIS PAGE WILL NOT LIST

Four fixtures a reader would expect are missing, and in each case the organiser is the reason. **Christmas Wonderland** at Gardens by the Bay publishes no 2026 dates, hours or ticketing — only "the magic's just getting started" — and last year's edition had opened on 29 November, so a five-week silence is itself a story. **Light to Night 2027** is unannounced. **Fuji Rock 2027** has no dates; listings showing "late July" are pattern-guessing. And the **Singapore Tennis Open** has moved to September 2027. **Moulin Rouge!** at Sands Theatre is held, not dropped: the venue refused this desk three times and listings disagree on when the run ends.[1]

SOURCES 1 Every dated row above was verified at the venue's, organiser's or official ticketing page on 29 October 2026: The Kallang's own event pages for the Singapore rows; the Singapore Writers Festival and Esplanade; Niseko United's lift-ticket page; the Sapporo Tourism Association; Melbourne Park's official Australian Open guide; the Japan Sumo Association's official ticket service; and Formula 1's own Japanese Grand Prix ticketing page. **Ticketmaster Singapore, SISTIC, Marina Bay Sands and Instagram all refused this desk, so no row is marked sold out unless a primary page says so, and no arena price appears that a venue did not publish. CP+ is the one exception noted in its own row. Two barred events stand in this magazine's ledger and appear nowhere above.** Where no price is published the row says so rather than estimating.

THE TABLE · FOUR NEW ROOMS

Zermatt Neo opened OVER on Tras Street; its only review was a hosted tasting

Four Singapore openings clear this magazine's ledger this week, and not one of them has an independent verdict — which is itself the week's finding.

OVER opened at 54 Tras Street on Wednesday **28 October**, the first restaurant from **Zermatt Neo**, Singapore's best-known competitive eater, built with The Wolfpack Investment Holdings. He calls it content-to-table: the menu comes from dishes he has eaten on camera, and each arrives in three sizes — **Lesser** for one, **Standard** for three or four, and **Challenge**, which is eight kilograms and feeds about ten. Curry Me Over is from **S$23**, the Shroyu-Clams from S$35; the challenges run **S$239 to S$469** and must be booked five days ahead.[1]

Be careful what you believe about it. The only published assessment of the cooking is Eatbook's, from the day it opened, which liked the curry rice and found a wing rub "a bit salty" — and **discloses that the meal was a media tasting hosted by the restaurant**. The other report is an interview and reaches no verdict; a third outlet refused this desk entirely. At forty-eight hours old, with no diner chatter anywhere, the honest line is **too new to call, and running on audience rather than kitchen**.[1]

The one with a cook behind it is **Casa Mori**, at 11 Dempsey Road, where **Willin Low** — the lawyer-turned-chef who more or less invented modern Singaporean cooking at Wild Rocket — has opened a Singaporean-Spanish room with the Spanish chef **José Alonso**. The dish that explains the idea is the **Kalipoqueta**, which puts the flavours of a curry puff inside a croquette; there are Iberico pork skewers under an Indonesian satay glaze. **No prices and no opening date have been published, and nobody has reviewed it.**[2]

Two more, both thinly documented. **HANDO**, at 28 Cavan Road in Jalan Besar, is a modern izakaya from **Jack Chang**, some twenty years in sushi: Hokkaido uni with cold-smoked ikura, binchotan-fired wagyu with wasabi salt, tsukune with a cured-yolk dip. And **Age.3**, the Ginza sando shop at ION Orchard, returns to this page — **34 varieties**, fried and filled to order. **Neither carries a published price.**[2]

1 of 4

ROOMS ON THIS PAGE WITH ANY PUBLISHED ASSESSMENT OF THE FOOD — AND THAT ONE WAS A MEAL THE RESTAURANT PAID FOR[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT IS ACTUALLY ON THE RECORD

Operators, mostly. Toh Jin Wei of The Wolfpack on why OVER exists: "Everyone was dying for an opportunity to have a physical place they could experience what they saw him eating." Neo on why he waited: **"There's two things that I always need. One is conviction in the food. One is conviction in the team." No diner comment, forum thread or social post was found for any of these four rooms, and none has been invented.** Eatbook's writer is the only person on record eating at any of them, and she was a guest.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · TWO NAMES THAT MAY NOT EXIST

This desk went through every October and November round-up in the local food press against its own ledger. Two names in those lists were dropped outright because **no evidence could be found that the restaurant exists at the address given** — one a Dempsey branch of a group whose three other outlets are easy to confirm, the other a hand-roll bar whose only trace is a company profile with no address. A listings round-up is a press release with a byline.[2]

TOO NEW TO CALL · HOSTED TASTING · BOOK FIVE DAYS AHEAD · NO PUBLISHED PRICE

The honest shape of the week: one room that is this month's noise, one with a genuine cook and no price, and two that exist mainly in a round-up. If you want a verdict rather than an announcement, wait a fortnight and come back — or go to a room this page has already stood behind.

SOURCES 1 Eatbook, 28 October 2026, which discloses the hosted tasting; AsiaOne's interview of the same week for the partnership, the pricing and the challenge structure. **A third local site returned 403 to every request, so nothing is attributed to it; its framing of the cooking as Asian fusion conflicts with the broadcaster's report of local comfort food, and published hours differ between two outlets — call before a lunch visit.** 2 A Singapore lifestyle title's new-openings guide of 28 October 2026, read at source, for the addresses, chefs and dishes at Casa Mori, HANDO and Age.3. **Each of those three rests on that single page: no price, no opening date and no review could be found for any of them, and that is stated in the text rather than filled in.** 3 Quotations from AsiaOne's interview. **Reddit, Burpple and Instagram were all unreachable, so there is no diner sentiment on this page at all.**

THE UNDERCURRENT · SRI LANKA'S ASWESUMA

Sri Lanka cut a million families from Aswesuma while the rupee outlay rose

The roll fell from 2,439,917 beneficiary families in 2025 to 1,251,522 in August 2026 — and the monthly payment went from Rs 11.2bn in November to Rs 11.83bn in July.

On Friday **11 September 2026**, in the Sri Lankan parliament, deputy finance minister **Dr Anil Jayantha Fernando** gave a number. **Aswesuma** — the cash transfer that replaced Samurdhi in 2023, and the welfare pillar of the island's IMF programme — was paying **1,251,522 families** in August. A year earlier it had been paying **2,439,917**. More than a million families had come off the roll in twelve months, and the re-verification behind it was about **ninety per cent** complete.[1]

What makes this an unreported story rather than a reported one is the second number. Over the same period the money did not fall. In November 2025 the scheme disbursed **Rs 11.2bn to 1,415,738 families**. In June 2026, **Rs 10.9bn to 1.37 million**. On **15 July 2026**, **Rs 11.83bn to 1,224,459**. The rupee line is flat to rising while the family line falls about fourteen per cent, because a gazette of **15 December 2025** raised the monthly rates — extremely poor from Rs 15,000 to **Rs 17,500**, poor from Rs 8,500 to **Rs 10,000**.[2]

The programme was built with an expiry date, and the schedule is public. Of its four household tiers, **transitional** ended in 2025 and **vulnerable** in **June 2026** — about **315,000** and **425,000** beneficiaries respectively. The remaining two, **poor** and **extremely poor**, run on the original timetable only to **June 2027**. Deputy minister **Wasantha Piyathissa** has said that under the Fund's conditions only the extremely poor should remain eligible by end-2028, and that **"another 400,000 will be removed next year and every year thereafter"**. In July, ministers said the scheme would be **"entirely phased out by 2030"**.[3]

> *"Another 400,000 will be removed next year and every year thereafter."*

Who is doing the removing is the question the rest of this essay is about. Fernando **rejected** suggestions that the World Bank or the IMF ordered the cut, attributing it to two tiers winding down on schedule. The Welfare Benefits Board's chairman **Nimal Kotawalagedara** put it in the passive voice available to any administrator: **"The reduction is taking place according to the gazette that was approved by Parliament."** Recertification itself is mandated by the Welfare Benefits Act of 2002. Nobody, in other words, decided anything.[1]

And the government elected to end austerity is the one administering it. In November 2025 **Sunil Handunnetthi**, industry minister and a figure in the party leading the National People's Power government, told a public meeting that **Aswesuma beneficiaries "should be ashamed"**, that the payment was **"like begging legally"**, and that "the goal should be to end Aswesuma through a clear program and plan". He added: "I would be happy to see the day when this subsidy no longer exists."[4]

The administrative detail that makes the scale concrete arrived in May. A payment file was uploaded twice to the Bank of Ceylon, and **Rs 248.8 million** went out a second time to **49,759** beneficiaries in the "poor" category; relief for some **1.7 million** families had been processed **manually, outside the ministry's own information system**, and the money was clawed back from the following month's allowance. For scale: the 2025 budget put total social protection at **Rs 749bn**, of which Aswesuma was **Rs 232bn** and public-service pensions **Rs 479.7bn** for about 730,000 pensioners.[2]

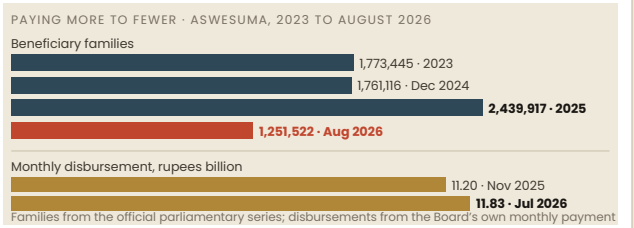
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FAMILIES REMOVED FROM THE ROLL BETWEEN 2025 AND AUGUST 2026 — WHILE THE MONTHLY DISBURSEMENT ROSE BY ABOUT SIX HUNDRED MILLION RUPEES[2]

SOURCES 1 The Morning (Colombo), 13 September 2026, reporting the deputy minister's statement to Parliament of 11 September and carrying the official beneficiary series from the 2023 launch; the Welfare Benefits Board chairman in the same report. 2 Hiru News, 12 November 2025, for the November disbursement; The Morning, 18 June and 15 July 2026, for the June and July figures and the phase split; the December 2025 gazette rates as reported by The Morning, 13 September 2026. **An October 2026 payment figure is in circulation but its source refused this desk, so it is not printed.** 3 Citizen.lk, 25 June 2026, for the tier sizes at removal; The Morning, 5 and 8 July 2026, for the removal programme and the 2030 phase-out. 4 Daily FT, 7 November 2025. **The Morning's own reporting gives the transitional tier's end as both April and December 2025, and the extremely-poor rate as both Rs 17,500 and Rs 17,000; the earlier and higher figures are printed, and the conflict is noted here rather than resolved.**

Aswesuma is not a list of names. It is a scoring machine: households are rated on **twenty-two indicators across six dimensions**, and the score decides the tier, which decides the rate, which decides the duration — six months to three years depending on the severity of the poverty found. This is what development economists call proxy-means testing, and Sri Lanka has built one of Asia's most elaborate versions of it, on a household database funded by a **US$200m** World Bank loan in 2023.[1]

The machine does not work very well, and the people who measure it say so. The Centre for Poverty Analysis puts Aswesuma's **inclusion error at 26 per cent and its exclusion error at 58** — a quarter of recipients are not poor, and most poor people get nothing. Samurdhi, the scheme it replaced and was meant to improve on, had an exclusion error of **48**. The Institute of Policy Studies found **40 per cent of food-insecure households** outside the programme altogether. Its own published target was to deliver **60 per cent** of benefits to the poorest fifth by 2026; it reached **48.2**, rated "partially achieved".[2]



The caseload fell by about half while the money did not move. *Meridian* original, from the figures cited here.

The database itself is smaller than the country. The Bank's loan built a register covering **3.6 million households**; the **2024 census counted 6.1 million**. **US$55.9m** of that loan was still undisbursed in January 2026. So the instrument that decides who is poor in Sri Lanka has never seen two-fifths of Sri Lankan households, and the exclusion error it produces is worse than the scheme it replaced.[1]

Now the part that is almost never stated plainly. **The IMF's binding condition is a rupee floor on social spending, reviewed quarterly — not a coverage floor.** Mission chief **Evan Papageorgiou** confirms the mechanism and that Sri Lanka met it at both end-December 2025 and end-March 2026. The written commitment on the scheme itself is narrower still: to **"obtain Cabinet approval of an updated graduation strategy"**. The country report does not require the removal of any particular tier.[3]

Read those two sentences together and the mechanism is complete. A government can pass every quarterly test while cutting a million families, provided it pays more to the ones who remain. The austerity does not appear in the fiscal metrics at all. It appears at the Divisional Secretariat, where the lists are posted and the appeals are lodged — and nowhere else.[3]

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INCLUSION AND EXCLUSION ERROR, PER CENT: A QUARTER OF RECIPIENTS ARE NOT POOR, AND MOST POOR HOUSEHOLDS GET NOTHING AT ALL[2]

THE CHATTER · BEGGING, LEGALLY

The local argument is not about arithmetic; it is about shame. **Gayathri Nawarathna**, writing in *Groundviews* after the minister's remarks: **"Social welfare is not begging — it is the mark of a caring and civilised society"**, adding that "every rupee distributed through aswesuma comes from public revenue". **Iromi Perera** of Colombo Urban Lab, whose essay is titled *Legalised begging and elegant targeting*, makes the structural point: **"Targeting or selection of beneficiaries only seeds tensions on the ground"**, and social protection "is a right and should not be viewed as charity". Her survey work found Aswesuma reaching only **34 to 44 per cent** of poor or food-insecure urban households.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · SOME OF THE MILLION WERE CORRECTIONS

A twenty-six per cent inclusion error means a quarter of recipients were not poor, so a share of the removals are the machine working, not failing. **About 7,000** people were taken off for having claimed on false information. And **Dr Harsha de Silva**, the opposition MP who chairs parliament's public-finance committee, attacks the scheme from the other direction entirely: citing academic work putting exclusion at **58 per cent**, he has demanded a **scientific pilot of 3,000 families** before any extension. On Samurdhi he was blunter — of **Rs 27bn** allocated in the 2025 budget, he says **Rs 22bn went to officers' salaries and Rs 5bn reached the poor**: "This is an inefficient system."[5]

SOURCES 1 The Institute of Policy Studies' assessment as reported by the Sunday Times, 1 June 2025, for the scoring instrument; Echelon, 10 August 2026, for the World Bank loan, the register size against the 2024 census, the undisbursed balance and the targeting indicator. **The Morning reports twenty-one assessment criteria where IPS reports twenty-two across six dimensions; the IPS figure is printed.** 2 The Centre for Poverty Analysis and the Institute of Policy Studies as reported by The Morning, 24 March 2025; the urban coverage range from the Centre for a Smart Future, 7 January 2026. 3 News First, 4 June 2026, reporting the IMF mission chief; Echelon, 10 August 2026, for the text of the written commitment. 4 *Groundviews*, 12 November 2025; the Centre for a Smart Future essay, 7 January 2026, first published in Daily FT on 18 December 2025. 5 The Morning, 5 July 2026, for the false-information removals; Daily FT, 24 January 2026, for the committee chairman's case.

Here is the claim. Sri Lanka has built a sophisticated poverty-targeting machine and is using it not to widen a safety net but to retire one — and because the binding external constraint is denominated in rupees rather than in households, the retirement is invisible in every metric a lender checks. Proxy-means testing has become austerity's alibi: a political decision to withdraw support is converted into an administrative finding about twenty-two indicators. Graduation from poverty is happening by gazette.[1]

The comparison that proves it is not a theory is Brazil, which owns the same technology and chose differently. Brazil's single registry recorded single-person households rising from **1.84 million in December 2018 to 5.88 million in 2022** — an obvious artefact — and the Lula government ran a *pente-fino*, a fine-tooth comb, removing about **1.7 million** single-member families from Bolsa Família. But the comb ran both ways: in 2023 Brazil **excluded 3.4 million families and added 2.9 million** between March and December, with a 2024 target of **4.7 million** registry updates.[2]

A recertification drive is a gate, not a valve. Brazil welded neither direction shut.

The difference is not the software. It is that Brazil's tiers carry no statutory expiry and Sri Lanka's do. Aswesuma's transitional tier ended, its vulnerable tier ended in June, and its remaining two are scheduled to stop in **June 2027**. And Sri Lanka has itself shown the valve can open in the other direction: in an earlier round **300,000 additional families were found to qualify** after a review of some 640,000 appeals and objections.[3]

Scale matters for whether any of this is defensible, and the World Bank published the scale on **7 October**. At the $4.20-a-day line, Sri Lankan poverty went from **11.5 per cent in 2019** to a **20.7** peak in 2023, and is forecast at **15.8 this year** and 14.8 next. At the **$8.30** line it is **61.1 per cent** in 2025 and still **55.7** in 2028. Which line you think a safety net should be set to is the whole argument: 15.8 per cent is roughly three and a half million people, which a roll of 1.2 million families can nearly cover. Sixty-one per cent is thirteen and a half million, which it cannot.[4]

Two further facts sit awkwardly beside the schedule. **Cyclone Ditwah** hit in November 2025, affecting **two million people** and causing **$4.1bn** of damage, and the Bank expects poverty and vulnerability to worsen in the affected districts. And interest payments consumed **nearly two-thirds of government revenue** in 2024 — which is the honest reason a government of the left is administering this, and not a moral failing of ministers.[4]

THE CHATTER · SIX MONTHS WITHOUT

Professor Ananda Jayawickreme of the University of Peradeniya asks the question the schedule does not answer: removed families may reapply, but **"reapplications take time, at least six months. How are those people expected to survive until then?"** And he names the test directly: **"if people are being removed simply to satisfy IMF conditions, then we are in trouble."** The deputy minister's answer is procedural — "They can reapply if they believe they are still entitled" — though he has also said the government is "holding discussions with the IMF to allow more concessions for the poor".[5]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT WOULD FALSIFY THIS

Three things, and the first is already on paper. **The World Bank's own 2026–30 country framework assumes Aswesuma reaches 7.4 million beneficiaries by 2027, up from 4.4 million in 2025 — a 68 per cent increase.** If the recertified list restores coverage rather than shrinking it, the reading above fails. Second: in late September the government said it **will not** remove the remaining million families in 2027 unless their incomes improve — a partial reversal two months after the phase-out was announced. Third: if the Fund's report truly requires no tier removal, then this is Colombo's austerity wearing a Washington costume, and must be argued as such.[6]

Which is the point. The name on this policy is the International Monetary Fund's. The hands are in Colombo, and the only written instruction anyone can produce is to obtain cabinet approval of a strategy. When the FT writes this up, that is the sentence it will have to deal with.

SOURCES 1 The argument is this desk's, built on the figures cited on p21 and p22. 2 Brazilian press reporting of the Ministry of Social Development's registry review, 5 February 2024. 3 The tier schedule as on p21; **the 300,000 reinstatements are from a Sri Lankan outlet that refused this desk and are printed as reported, not read at source.** 4 The World Bank's October 2026 poverty assessment as reported by Daily FT, 7 October 2026, including the Acting Country Manager's remark that "real wages are still lower than they were before the crisis"; the cyclone and revenue figures from Echelon, 10 August 2026. 5 The Morning, 5 July and 4 June 2026. 6 Echelon, 10 August 2026, for the country framework's beneficiary target and for the text of the Fund's commitment; The Morning, 29 September 2026, for the partial reversal. **A report that the Board has already published a recertified roster below one million families could not be verified — the outlet carrying it returned an empty body twice, and no other source repeats it. If it is right, the first of this essay's predictions is already met. Western coverage check: searches naming the New York Times, BBC, Reuters, the Financial Times and The Economist against this subject returned nothing from any of the five.**

THE LAST WORD

The label and the hands

A Swedish company sells the best gloves in the world. Open its own product feed and the eight pairs that cost the most are attributed to a co-operative in Hungary; the only Swedish supplier on the list makes the leather balm. Nobody is lying. The name is honest about everything except where the hands are.

The same gap ran through the week without being hunted for. A central bank's president resigned, and the appointment of her successor belongs to heads of government, which both the French left and the French right said out loud (p3). A committee voted to hold the price of money while its own trading desk was instructed to buy Treasury bills (p14). Samsung made ninety-nine per cent of its profit selling memory, and the division that makes its phones lost money buying it (p7). A study measured children's social-media use by asking the children and their depression by asking the parents, and reported the result as one finding (p12).

Two pages say it plainly, and they are the ones worth keeping. A glider pilot on an old mailing list explains why his sport is cheap: it runs on "free unskilled and skilled labour, provided by club members gratis" (p17). And in Colombo a million families have come off a welfare roll under a programme everyone calls an IMF condition — while the only written instruction anyone can produce asks the cabinet to approve a strategy (p21). The label said Washington. The hands were at home.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

MERIDIAN · No. 148 · 30 October 2026

SOURCES A note on method. This edition's load-bearing figures were read where they are published: a central bank's own press release and press-conference transcript; the Federal Reserve's statement and the implementation note issued beside it; the Bureau of Economic Analysis on growth and on personal income; the United States Treasury's daily par and real yield curves; two Korean companies' filings furnished to the Securities and Exchange Commission, and two American ones' quarterly exhibits; a glove maker's own machine-readable product feed, read in four pages; six journal papers at their journals or at PubMed Central; a Singapore ministry's own statement and a second ministry's factsheet; club fee schedules in three countries; manufacturers' and dealers' own storefronts in five currencies; merge requests, issues and release notes on public code repositories; and venue, promoter or museum pages for every dated event on p19. **Figures that are this magazine's own arithmetic — the ten-year breakeven on p14, the share price of a syndicate on p16 — say so where they appear.** Where a host refused us — **Reddit for the fifteenth issue running, and so there is no Reddit sentiment anywhere in this book; Reuters, the Guardian, CNBC and Politico Europe; EUFOR's own site; the Housing Board's own release body; Permanent Style, which is the single most important source on p6 and which is quoted here only through a search index; the principal American glider dealer; Billboard's album charts, behind a payment wall; Ticketmaster Singapore, SISTIC and Marina Bay Sands; and two Sri Lankan outlets** — the page says so rather than quietly substituting. **A correction to No. 147 runs on p11: the critic figures this desk printed for *Clayface* were captured mid-count and have since settled. Every photograph in this issue was opened and looked at before it was captioned.**